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SAFE SHORE

2 rescued from sunken ship brought to Odisha

NEWS » PAGE 14

TRAINING ACCIDENT

Aircraft crash kills pilot, instructor in Uttar Pradesh

NEWS » PAGE 14



BORDER DIFFERENCES

India, China ready to 'clarify perceptions'

NEWS » PAGE 12



PARLEY

Is English a foreign language in our country?

People have adopted it for its many advantages

OPINION » PAGE 11



EXTRAORDINARY EFFORT

Defiant Dinusha earns a draw for Sri Lanka

SPORT » PAGE 17



Nepal flood toll hits 389; rescue work in top gear

Over 800 people rescued after the flash flood, 910 remain missing, say authorities

517 foreign nationals unaccounted for; PM Shah reaches nearest motorable town

Alert sounded along Bhotekoshi river as satellite images show blockage upstream

Probe on to determine the role of glacial lakes in the devastating flood, says Nepal

Sanjeev Satgainya
KATHMANDU

The death toll in the flash flood in Nepal's Rasuwa district bordering Tibet touched 389 on Thursday, with 910 people still missing. Nepal's government issued a fresh flood alert after satellite imagery showed that a lake had formed upstream of the Bhotekoshi river due to a blockage, and warned that it could burst.

Nepal's Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal termed the flood "one of the largest natural disasters we have experienced in recent memory" even as authorities continued a massive search-and-rescue operation. "Towns after towns were wiped out in a span of a couple of hours," he said.

Personnel from the Nepal Army, police, and the Armed Police Force raced against time to rescue survivors from mountain villages that were swept away by the flash flood on Wednesday morning.

According to authorities, more than 800 people were rescued from flood-affected areas as of Thursday night.

Of the 910 missing, 517 are foreign nationals with people from more than 30 countries remaining unaccounted for, they said.

Raising concerns about another possible flood, the government said "satellite imagery and preliminary analysis indicate that water has accumulated at the site where flooding was reported" on Wednesday. "The lake is continuing to rise, and authorities have warned that it could breach or burst, potentially sending a sudden surge of water downstream." It urged residents, travellers, rescue personnel, and others in the downstream areas to remain alert. "It is



Swept away: Sludge surrounds damaged buildings at Bidur in Nuwakot district of Nepal on Thursday, more than 24 hours after the deadly flood tore through the region. AFP

advised that people stay away from riverbanks and other vulnerable areas... until further notice," it said.

Nepal's Prime Minister Balendra Shah reached Bidur, the district headquarters of Nuwakot, which abuts Rasuwa, by road. With 19 bridges and 40 ki-

lometres of roads damaged, it is the last point up to which vehicles can reach.

It is still unclear what caused the flash flood. According to the Nepal government, satellite imagery indicated that an avalanche in the Himalayan region triggered a

surge of an unusually large volume of water. "Further investigations are under way to determine the role of possible glacial lakes and related events," it said.

EDITORIAL
» PAGE 10
MORE REPORTS ON
» PAGE 13

At least 290 Indians missing, says Centre

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

In a "preliminary assessment" of the situation following the flash flood in Nepal, the External Affairs Ministry on Thursday said at least 290 Indian nationals remain "uncontactable".

"Urgent efforts are under way to ascertain the status and well-being of all Indians in the flood-affected areas," said External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, adding that India is "working closely with the Nepalese side".

After sending an aircraft carrying relief materials to the disaster-hit neighbour on Wednesday, the Ministry on Thursday said that a



Relatives of those missing wait near a rescue camp in Trishuli, Nepal, on Thursday. PTI

second consignment of humanitarian assistance and disaster relief materials were handed over to Nepal. Additional support would be extended to the Himalayan nation, it said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12

21 pilgrims from T.N. rescued, says MEA official

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A total of 21 persons from Tamil Nadu, who were on the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, have been rescued in Nepal, where flash floods wreaked havoc in three districts, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Thursday. In a social media post, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal disclosed the names of the 21 persons.

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay held an emergency meeting with Ministers and officials in Chennai.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

NEARBY



No valid grounds to nullify my poll win, Vijay tells HC

CHENNAI
Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has contended before the Madras High Court that his rival candidate in the Tiruchi East Assembly constituency, S. Irigo Irudayaraj of the DMK, had failed to demonstrate how the alleged use of children in poll campaign could be raised as a ground for nullifying an election. » PAGE 8

MLAs lock horns over welfare measures for SCs

CHENNAI
The Assembly witnessed a heated exchange on Thursday between legislators of the TVK-led government and the Opposition over the implementation of welfare schemes for the Scheduled Castes (SCs) under the former DMK regime. » PAGE 8

Food allowance for SC/ST hostel students to go up

CHENNAI
The monthly food allowance will be increased from ₹1,400 to ₹1,800 for school hostel students belonging to the Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs), and from ₹1,500 to ₹2,000 for college hostel students from these communities, Minister for Social Justice Vanni Arasu said on Thursday. » PAGE 8

Four Nagas killed in ambush amid Manipur peace efforts

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Unidentified gunmen on Thursday morning ambushed and killed four Naga civilians between Makui Ashang and Thanamba Naga villages in Manipur's Kuki-dominated Kangpokpi district.

Officials said the gunmen opened fire on at least six persons who were travelling from Makui to Senapati, a Naga-majority district. The authorities suspect that some groups are trying to undermine the State government's peace-building measures.

The United Naga Council (UNC), an apex body of Manipur's Naga communities, blamed Kuki extremist groups for the attack though no outfit has claimed responsibility. It condemned the "barbaric and calculated" attack on the Liangmai Naga civilians and called it a "direct challenge to peace, the Indo-Naga peace process, and to the very existence of Nagas in our ancestral lands".

Manipur Chief Minister Yumnan Khemchand Singh and Home Minister Govindas Konhoujam condemned the "senseless violence" and said it "strikes at our collective efforts to restore peace and normalcy".

CONTINUED ON
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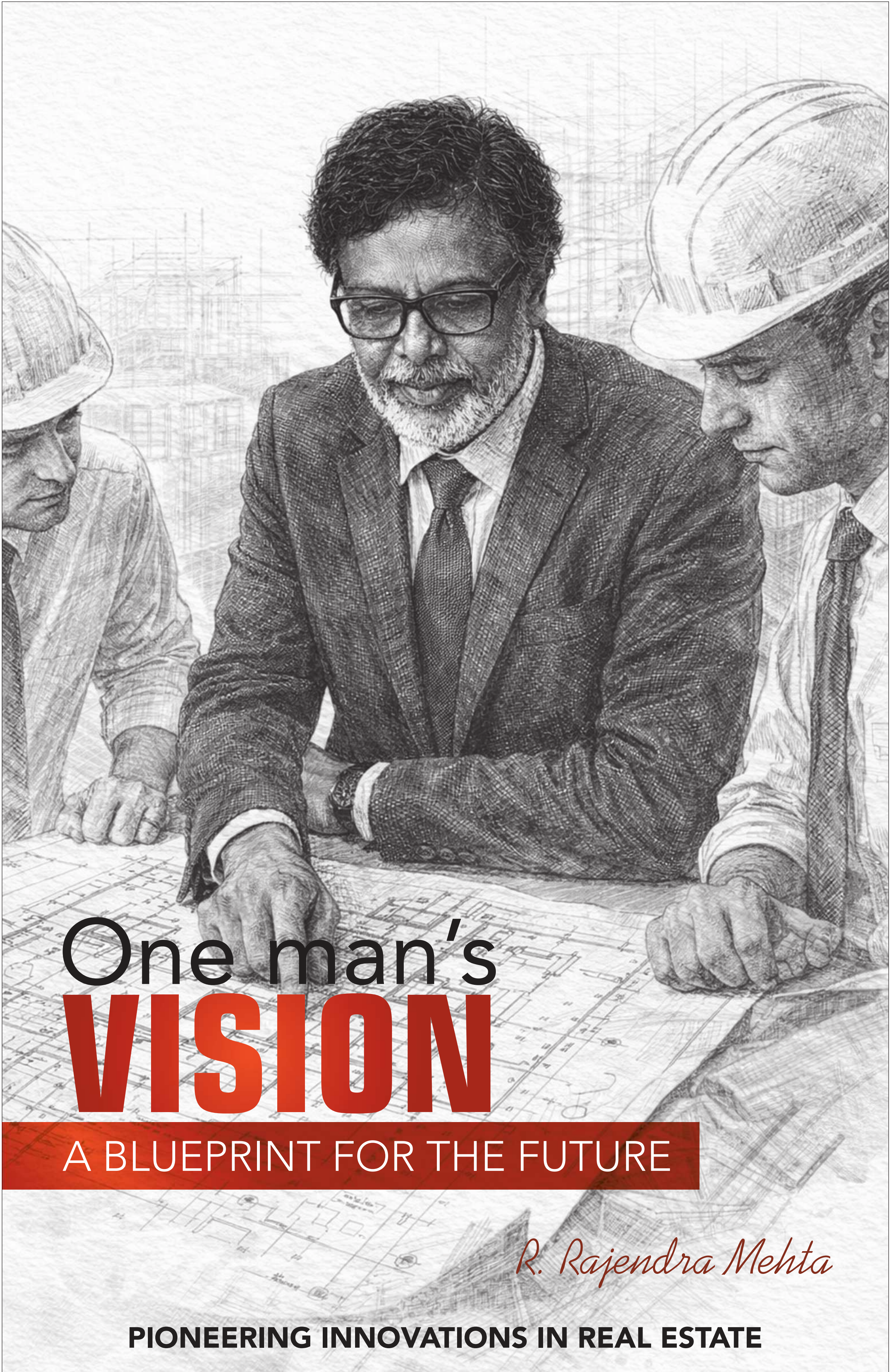
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Biography

*Your dreams may have been cut short,
But our combined journey is
as fulfilling as your dreams were!*

*We may miss your presence, but
You are always in our thoughts and deeds,
which is ever lasting!*

*That said, it is just not one time annual ritual,
It is to share the thoughts and glories of
an extraordinary human
with companions, colleagues and compatriots!*

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Can Chennai airport handle widebody Code F aircraft?

Officials say that the airport can handle Code F aircraft on the main runway when certain procedures are in place. Antonov An-124 Ruslan, one of the largest cargo aircraft, was received in October last year

PORT CALL

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In the light of the Tamil Nadu government scrapping the massive second airport at Parandur, social media has been abuzz with debates on what the city could be missing out before a new airport is a reality in the future. Among them is why Chennai airport doesn't handle Code F type aircraft such as A380 (very large wingspan ranges from 65 metres - 80 metres; passenger capacity: over 500).

Officials of Airports Authority of India (AAI) clarify that while Chennai airport is classified as Code E airport the main runway can handle



Although the Chennai airport is classified as a Code E airport, there have been instances where Code F aircraft were handled. X/AACHNAIRPORT

Code F aircraft when special procedures are in place. A Code E airport can handle long-haul, widebody aircraft such as B777 or A330. The wingspan of such aircraft range from 52 metres - 65 metres with the passenger capacity ranging from 200 to 400.

In the past, on a few occa-

sions, Chennai airport has handled Code F type aircraft but there is no passenger boarding bridge in place for such an aircraft, officials said. For instance, in October last year, Chennai airport handled Antonov An-124 Ruslan, one of the largest cargo aircraft. In 2019, the airport received two Boeing 747-800

aircraft (Code F). Two years later, two taxiways commissioned at the airport too were suitable to handle Code F type aircraft, officials said. "The main runway of the airport is capable of handling Code F type aircraft under Specialised Standard Operating Procedures. But we must understand that there are very few Code F type passenger aircraft. We handle several Code E type aircraft for international operations regularly. When there is a scheduled Code F type, we can certainly handle it," an official said.

Two years ago, in a meeting held with AAI, the Tamil Nadu government had urged to make Chennai airport Code F compliant for regular operations and that it would give an impetus to the State's economy.

Police question ex-Minister Sekarbabu over clash between DMK and TVK members on polling day

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The police questioned DMK MLA and former Minister P.K. Sekarbabu for three hours in connection with a case relating to a clash between the DMK members and function-

aries of the TVK in the Harbour constituency during polling. The dispute involved TVK functionaries, including the party's Harbour candidate Sinora Ashok, and members of DMK led by Mr. Sekarbabu. What began as a verbal alter-

cation escalated into a scuffle and physical assault. The police said some TVK functionaries were injured in the clash. TVK functionary Muralidharan lodged a complaint with the North Beach police. Following an inquiry, police registered a case and is-

sued summons to Mr. Sekarbabu, directing him to appear for questioning. On Wednesday, he appeared before the inspector of police at the North Beach police station. His statement was recorded and then he was allowed to leave.

Chennai grew on me like no other place, says Head of Police Force

I came to Chennai in 1996. It was a city that was new to me, far removed from the places where I had lived until then. Yet, over the years, Chennai grew on me like no other place. I developed a deep emotional bond with the city and, more importantly, with its people.

Having served Chennai in different capacities - as DCP Flower Bazaar, DCP Traffic, Additional Commissioner of Police, South Chennai, Commissioner of Police, and later as DGP - I have had the privilege of experiencing the city at different levels and from different perspectives. I still fondly remember my days as a DCP, when I worked closely with my team on the ground. Those years involved immense hard work, but every challenge was more than compensated for by the warmth, trust, and affection of the people.

As Commissioner of Police, I



Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal



From the archives: American Fulbright scholar Jon Higgins presents a Carnatic music concert at Sri Krishna Gana Sabha on September 30, 1966. This photo and more are on display at *The Hindu* Made of Chennai Archival Photo Exhibit as part of Madras Month celebrations. The exhibition will be on at *The Hindu* office till September 14 and is open to the public from 10 a.m. to 6.30 p.m. on all days, except Sundays. To visit, register for free at madeofchennai.thehindu.com/

witnessed another extraordinary facet of Chennai during the difficult days of COVID-19. At a time when cities across the world were struggling with an unprecedented crisis, Chennai stood out for the remarkable way in which its people came together. Chennaites reached out to one another, shared essential supplies, supported those in need, and, perhaps most importantly, shared their compassion and humanity.

CM launches pinhole pupilloplasty centre

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday inaugurated a pinhole pupilloplasty centre at Dr. Agarwal's Eye Hospital, Chennai.

The centre will focus on pinhole pupilloplasty (PPP), a microsurgical technique developed by Amar Agarwal, chairman of Dr. Agarwal's Eye Hospitals, designed to improve the quality of vision in patients with conditions such as corneal scars, irregular corneas, high corneal aberrations, and certain post-surgical optical distortions.

Dr. Agarwal said, "Two to five crore people are estimated to be waiting for donor corneas every year in the world. Donor corneas are simply not available in sufficient numbers, even in India. The second major challenge is rejection. Patients who undergo a corneal transplant also



Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay at the launch of the pinhole pupilloplasty centre at Dr. Agarwal's Eye Hospital in the city on Thursday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

need medication for the rest of their lives. Today, we have a technique called PPP. Instead of removing the scar, we bypass it by creating a small pinhole in a clear part of the cornea, allowing light to enter the eye."

The smaller aperture helps block scattered and distorted light rays and allows better-focused rays to reach the retina.

This pinhole effect can reduce the impact of higher-order optical aberrations and thereby improve functional vision and visual quality.

Manoj Khatri, Director, Vitreo-Retinal Services; Athiya Agarwal, Director; Adil Agarwal, Chief Executive Officer; and S. Soundari, Regional Head of Clinical Services, were present.

Govt. forms 3 new elephant corridors

B. Aravind Kumar
CHENNAI

Deeply committed to the conservation of Asian Elephants, and their long-term survival, and to mitigate human-wildlife conflict, the Tamil Nadu government notified three elephant corridors in Cauvery North Wildlife Sanctuary on Thursday.

Pursuant to the interim orders of the Madras High Court, the government had constituted two committees to identify elephant

corridors in two landscapes with Palghat gap as the boundary. The committees submitted reports in respect of three elephant corridors, i.e. Jawalagiri - Ulbanda - Thaggatti corridor (18.50 km), Jawalagiri - Panai - Anchetty corridor (20.90 km), and Bilikkal Jawalagiri corridor (2.20 km) in Cauvery North Wildlife Sanctuary in Hosur Forest Division for recognition as elephant corridors.

The PCCF and Chief Wildlife Warden said these corridors serve as a vital and viable connec-

tivity link between the interstate boundary of Tamil Nadu and Karnataka.

The elephants migrate across the boundary in response to monsoonal changes and habitat requirements and the continued survival and ecological security of the elephant population in this region was dependent upon the preservation and protection of these corridors, he said.

Based on his recommendations, the government has notified three elephant corridors.

CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy Madras
Today: At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall 6.00 p.m. to 7.50 p.m. - The Music Academy Madras - HCL Concerts - Bharatanatyam recital by Shambhavi Jagadish.

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MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Narada Gana Sabha
Phone: 24993201
Today Main Hall (Sathguru Gnanananda Hall) Drama - 6.30pm - Historical Drama Festival - Natakakavalur Chemmal R.S.Manohar's NXGS presents "Lankeshwaran" written by Thuraiyoor Murthy. Direction - S.Shivprasadh & S.Sruuthi.

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

BRAHMA GANA SABHA, KARTIK FINE ARTS, NARADA GANA SABHA & SRI PARTHASARATHYSWAMY SABHA at **Narada Gana Sabha Hall, Chennai**
Nalli HISTORICAL DRAMA FESTIVAL - 2026
Today (Aug 28) **Natakakavalur Chemmal R. S. Manohar's NXGS** presents "**LANKESHWARAN**" Written by Thuraiyoor Murthy. Direction: S.Shivprasadh & S. Sruuthi. Tomorrow Mother Creations presents **JAGATHGURU- All are welcome.**
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Kartik Fine Arts
24997788 / 9840928049
Kartik Fine Arts, Narada Gana Sabha, Brahma Gana Sabha and Sri Parthasarathy Swami Sabha jointly present Nalli historical drama festival-2026. Today 6.30pm at Narada Gana Sabha Main Hall Nataka Kavalur Chemal R.S.Manohar's NXGS' 'Lankeshwaran' Written by 'Kalaaimamani' Thuraiyoor Murthy. Direction: S. Shivprasadh & S. Sruuthi. All are welcome.

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PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Pradeep R, S/o A. Ramalingam R/o. 1, 8th Street, Nandanam Extn, Nandanam, Chennai 600035, have changed my name to Pradeep Ramalingam as per the affidavit dated 25/8/2026.

I, Leishram Nirma residing at Aristo F1, Plot 14, Sri Kandan Nagar Ganapathi Thotham, Ponniammamedu, have changed my name from Leishram Nirma to Nirma Thingom. Henceforth I shall be known and referred to as Nirma Thingom for all purposes.

I, J.S. Viha Sree Amritha, D/o J.Selvam, DOB 15-07-1999, Native District: Chennai, residing at No. 11/9, Adhikesavan St, Subramanya Salai, Saidapet, Chennai - 600015, shall henceforth be known as Viha Sree Amritha. Former Name: J.S. Viha Sree Amritha. New Name: Viha Sree Amritha

I, VARADHA Rajan, Vijay Raghavan Senkurchi, alias S.V. Vijay Raghavan, Vijay Raghavan V Senkurchi & Vijay Raghavan s/o S.V. Varadha Rajan, r/o B6, Casa Grand Aldea, Bharathiya Nagar Main Rd, Thorapakkam, Chennai-600097, have changed my name to Vijay Raghavan Senkurchi vide affidavit dt. 26/08/2026, sworn before Notary R.Gomathi

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ISSN 0971 - 751X

CM CH-CHE

INBRIEF



B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

BLOs are the backbone of democracy: Gyanesh Kumar

Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar on Thursday said booth-level officers (BLOs) serve as the backbone of democracy. At the Election Commission’s regional conference on ‘ELC & ECINET’ held in Chennai, he addressed nearly 1,000 students and educators, and interacted with around 500 BLOs. The conference was organised to boost youth participation and enhance ground-level election preparedness across Tamil Nadu and Puducherry. Addressing the interactive session with the 500 BLOs, the Chief Election Commissioner highlighted their crucial role in elections. Addressing the media, Mr. Gyanesh Kumar said BLOs acted as the foundation of democracy, and emphasised their vital contribution in maintaining accurate, error-free voter lists.

☀️🌧️ Timings CHENNAI			
FRIDAY, AUG. 28			
☀️ RISE	05:58	🌇 SET	18:23
🌧️ RISE	18:32	🌅 SET	05:53
SATURDAY, AUG. 29			
☀️ RISE	05:58	🌇 SET	18:22
🌧️ RISE	19:10	🌅 SET	06:42
SUNDAY, AUG. 30			
☀️ RISE	05:58	🌇 SET	18:21
🌧️ RISE	19:48	🌅 SET	07:32

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	36	26
Chennai Airport	37	27
Chennai City	37	27

Chennai Airport Today
35°C The weather will be warm. Chances of light rain and thundershower at few places. Night also will be comfortable.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
36°C Day will be very warm. Morning will be comfortable. Short spell of light rain and thundershower is a chance. Night also will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU
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Government of India
Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports
(Department of Sports)

Applications are invited from eligible officers/candidates for 20 posts across administrative, judicial, IT, accounting, and secretarial cadres (Pay Levels 4-13) in the National Sports Tribunal (NST), Delhi, on a deputation basis. Detailed eligibility, qualifications, and procedure are given in the Vacancy Circular dated 07.08.2026 on <https://yas.gov.in/en/sports>. Last date to apply: 06.09.2026 (17:30 Hrs).

Sd/-
Director (Sports)

CBC 47108/11/0001/2627

दक्षिण पूर्व मध्य रेलवे			
ई-टेंडर नोटिस नं. एनआईटी/14/26/34,		तिथि: 18.08.2026	
क्र. सं.	निविदा संख्या	संक्षिप्त विवरण	टेंडर बंद/खुलने की तिथि एवं समय
1	03262890	हेलिकॉप्टर सिंग	04.09.2026 At 10:30 hrs
2	04251267D	सोलिड कोर पोर्सलेयन 9 टन इंसुलेटर	03.09.2026 At 10:30 hrs
3	08261302A	फायर इक्विपिंग/इंजिनर विद्युत एंटी-थेफ्ट असेसमेंट	10.09.2026 At 10:30 hrs
4	03263392	ब्रेक पाईप सपोर्ट एंगल एज पर ड्राईंग नं. एस.ई.सी. रेलवे/ एसके नं. डब्ल्यूआरएस/आर-1667, एल-4.	08.09.2026 At 10:30 hrs
5	03261344A	बोल्सटर सिंग आउटर फॉर बॉक्सएन-एचएस वैगन दू आरडीएसओ डीआरजी. नं. डब्ल्यूडी 92058-एस-5, एल-14.	07.09.2026 At 10:30 hrs
6	06260091B	इंलास्टिक रेल, विलप (ईआरसी) एमके-डी विद्युत टॉप फॉर 60केजी यूआईसी/ 52केजी रेल सेक्शन डीआरजी: (आरडीएसओ) आरडीएसओ टी. 5919 एल-2 स्पेसि: (आरडीएसओ) आईआरएस/ टी-31-2025 सिक्स्थ रिजिजन.	04.09.2026 At 10:30 hrs
7	03261477A	संक्षिप्त फोट फॉर एएआर स्टैंडर्ड कार्टेज बियरिंग दू आर. डी. एस.ओएस ड्राईंग नं. डब्ल्यूडी-87019-एस-1. एल-3.	16.09.2026 At 10:30 hrs
8	03261557	कंपलीट सेट फॉर ईएमटी लोड बॉक्स असेसमेंट ऑफ बॉक्सएन वैगन	07.09.2026 At 10:30 hrs
9	05265098	अंडरग्राउंड जेली फिल्ट व्हाइ केबल फॉर सिग्नलिंग एण्ड टेलीकॉम इंस्टॉलेशन साईज: 6 व्हाइ x 0.9 एमएम डाय, आरडीएसओ स्पेसिफिकेशन नं. आईआरएस टीसी-30/2005 (वर्सन. 1) एमईएमेट नं. 1 दू-5 ऑर लेटेस्ट एमईएमेट.	24.09.2026 At 10:30 hrs
10	05265054	अंडरग्राउंड रेलवे सिग्नलिंग केबल अनसिकण्ड, पीव्हीसी इंसुलेटेड, पीव्हीसी इनर थिंथंड, अरमाइड एण्ड पीव्हीसी आउटर जैकेट विद्युत हाई कंडक्टिविटी एनीलड कॉपर कंडक्टर, साईज-12 कोर x 1.5 एसक्यूएमएम कनफर्मिंग दू आरडीएसओ स्पेसिफिकेशन नं. आईआरएस/ एस-63/ 2014, (रिवि. 4.0) विद्युत लेटेस्ट एमईएमेट.	18.09.2026 At 10:30 hrs
रेलवे को किसी निविदा के लिए शुद्धिपत्र जारी करने का अधिकार है, शुद्धिपत्र और ई खरीद की जरूरी सूचना वेब www.irops.gov.in पर देख सकते हैं।			
सहायक सामग्री प्रबंधक-III सीपीआर/10/360			

Govt. mulls corridor linking Tambaram and Chengalpattu

It had already announced, during the demands for grants for the Public Works Department, a plan to create an eight-lane road between Chennai and Kanniyakumari, says Aadhav Arjuna

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Public Works Minister Aadhav Arjuna told the Assembly on Thursday that the government would prepare a Detailed Project Report (DPR) to ease traffic congestion on roads linking Tiruvallur, Chengalpattu, and Mamallapuram to Chennai, and consider implementing the Tambaram-Chengalpattu elevated corridor.

Responding to former Chief Minister Edappadi K. Palaniswami, who sought to know whether the government would implement the Tambaram-Chengalpattu elevated corridor, conceived by the AIADMK government, Mr.



We will prepare a DPR for the roads around Chennai and the elevated corridor between Tambaram and Chengalpattu
AADHAV ARJUNA
Public Works Minister

Arjuna said the former Chief Minister was right in raising the issue. He said the government had already announced, during the demands for grants for the department, a plan to create an eight-lane road between Chennai and Kanniyakumari.

Mr. Palaniswami said the Centre was ready to implement the project, but it had been shelved by the

DMK government.

Mr. Arjuna said the government had directed officials to prepare a DPR for the eight-lane road.

“When we met the Union Minister, we discussed the issue for an hour as there is heavy traffic between Kanniyakumari and Chennai. Only an eight-lane road will ease traffic woes for the next 30 years, as the road witnesses a

large number of accidents,” he said.

The Minister said that while the distance between Tiruchi and Chengalpattu could be covered in four hours, it takes another three hours to travel from Chengalpattu to the airport.

“Similarly, Bengaluru to Tiruvallur can be covered easily, but reaching Poona-mallee is a tough task. The same is the case with the Mahabalipuram-Chennai route. We will prepare a DPR for the roads around Chennai and the elevated corridor between Tambaram and Chengalpattu. We have a meeting with the Union Minister next week, and will take steps to implement the project,” he said.

Thread and butter!



Speaker promises to prevent expunged remarks from being used on social media

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar on Thursday assured to look into ways of preventing social media platforms from carrying remarks expunged from the Assembly proceedings, citing practices followed in the United States and the United Kingdom.

He was responding to DMK member E.V. Velu, who had given two letters to the Speaker on the privilege of the House. Mr. Velu pointed out while the print media had refrained from publishing expunged remarks, social media was not adhering to the practice, thereby denigrating the dignity of the House.

When the letters were submitted, the Speaker had said the issue could be considered after the Privileges Committee was formed.

Mr. Prabhakar said there was a practice in the U.S. and the U.K. under which expunged remarks were not made public even though the proceedings continued to be broadcast live. “We are studying the practice. I will also consider the issue (raised by Mr.

Velu) without sending it to the Privileges Committee,” he said. Mr. Prabhakar also advised Secretaries of various departments to be present in the House when questions relating to their departments were taken up and important issues were raised.

Responding to Opposition Leader Udhayanidhi Stalin, who recalled the practice of officials being present in the House during Question Hour, the Speaker referred to speeches by former Leader of the House Duraimurugan and former Speaker P.T.R. Palanivel Rajan.

Earlier, PWD Minister Aadhav Arjuna said, unlike in the past, the Assembly proceedings were now broadcast live and officials were present in the “war room”.

DMK Deputy Leader K.N. Nehru said live broadcasting had always been there, but the entire proceedings were not broadcast. “When questions relating to different places are raised, the secretary sitting in the lobby can take notes. The Assembly is an important body. If the Chief Minister is not in the House, the Chief Secretary should be there,” he said.

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However you look at it, Madraspatnam, a mere lick of sand, has magically transformed itself, over 387 years, into a nearly-dazzling metropolis of the future. The Hindu’s week-long Madras Day series is a celebration of the journey that Chennai has travelled through, over the centuries, marking the route it took to get where it is today. This city has changed - from how it looks to how it sleeps to how it does business, or even eats. It is a fascinating journey, as you will see. Happy Madras Day!

Madras, a city that has always expanded its language to welcome new words into its fold

Telugu, Urdu, Hindi, Kannada, Sanskrit, English, and Dutch, all found their way into Madras *bashai*, a dialect shaped by many communities and popularised by Kollywood hits and young *Gaana* lyricists. Beyond this, each generation has its own linguistic starter pack, from *chappa* matter, peter, lol and yolo, to more recent delulu, brainrot, and skibidi

TRANSFORMING CITY

Sahana Mira S.
CHENNAI

If you go down the rabbit hole of how words travel from one language to another, you just have to listen to this dialect of Tamil that is Madras *bashai*. It is built around loan words as Chennai is formed not just of Tamil speakers; Telugu, Urdu, Hindi, Kannada, Sanskrit, English, and Dutch have all found their way into the Madras *bashai*, a dialect shaped by the many communities that called Madras home.

When Tamil absorbed the Urdu word *ghaliz*, it became *galeej* in the city’s lingo. Historian V. Sriram traces its origin to the time of the Nawab of Arcot or the Golconda Sultanate’s arrival at Santhome. Just like *galeej*, the quintessential Madras word for money, *duttu*, is believed to have evolved from the Dutch’s *duit*, a small coin used in the colonial era. Then there is *babbu*, be-



Triplicane, George Town, Royapuram, and Perambur have contributed to the evolution of the dialect.

jar, assault, and a whole roster of words that make up the medley called Madras *bashai*.

“This is not something unique to our city. It is a part of every city’s evolution as multiple people come and leave their own impress,” says Mr. Sriram. And naturally, languages don’t sit still. “*Machan* and *machi* as a colloquial term would not have existed a century ago, though *machan* as a proper relationship did. This kind of addition will continue to

happen. But what is interesting is we have this ancient Tamil word, *poromboke*, find acceptance in Madras *bashai* because it, perhaps, best sums up the situation in which it could be used,” he adds, also observing that Madras *bashai* will never become Chennai *bashai* because nobody wants to take ownership of it. Needless to say, it is the language of the city itself, where Triplicane, George Town, Royapuram, and Perambur have all contributed to its evolution.

When Kollywood’s big crossover came, the dialect travelled to Tamil-speaking audiences far and wide, with many actors, including Kamal Haasan, popularising the word *gaandu* through the film *Pammal K. Sambandam*, scripted by Crazy Mohan.

A consultant who lived in Chennai for 13 years, Saradhambal, says she was introduced to Madras *bashai* through actor Manorama’s dialogues in old Tamil films. “Being raised in Coimbatore, I have

heard this kind of Tamil only in old films. Something like “*Naastha thuntiya paana*” is so quirky. When I think of this dialect, Manorama *Aachi* comes to mind immediately,” she says.

Lyricists from the younger generation such as Vyasarpadi-based Rakesh took the dialect to the masses with *Danga Maari* from *Anegan*, which leans heavily into slang. Speaking of films, the dialect has found yet another cultural outlet in *Gaana*, a genre known far beyond Chennai. Rooted in Madras *baasha*, it tells the stories of working-class communities, particularly of North Chennai.

Beyond this specific dialect, the everyday slang of Chennai’s colleges has a life of its own, with every generation having their own little linguistic starter pack. A generation before millennials had their *kadi*, enthu cutlet, *chappa* matter, and peter. Then came the millennials, who grew up during the transition

from analogue to digital worlds, bringing lol, cool beans, yolo, and dude into everyday conversation, influenced by pop culture and internet spaces. With Gen Z, much of their slang is influenced by the urban English-speaking internet. Delusion became delulu, suspicious became sus, and there is brainrot, rizz, yapping, to name just a few. What sounded effortlessly cool to millennials can sound ancient to Gen alpha.

For 21-year-old graduates Raghav and Suresh, slang is also a kind of a code, a way of making sure the people in the room are in on the joke. “We use words like ‘fanum tax’, which is about how we are entitled to take a little bit of our friend’s food. They are now part of our everyday vocab,” they say.

However, Gen alpha has a different rulebook that is likely to leave everyone else scratching their heads. Nine-year-old Prakrithi S. says she knows some Gen

Z lingo but uses only words picked up from the online communities of her generation. At school, skibidi, gyatt, and even digits like 6-7 have become part of the vocabulary. “When our teacher asked us to read the sixth and seventh *sloka* at school, some of us were secretly moving our hands up and down, indicating the digits. It is just about a meme online that doesn’t mean anything, but it makes us happy, like an inside joke,” she shares.

Nekhaa N., a linguistics Master’s graduate from the University of Manchester, explains how the slang, though short-lived, keeps evolving. “The perception of language changes as generation changes, and that changes the way we use words,” she says, adding that slang is a product of exposure. Perhaps this is where the parallel lies. Just as Tamil absorbed words from the many languages it encountered and made them its own in Madras *bashai*, today’s youth pick up slang from the unthumbed, overwhelming digital spaces they inhabit.

FROM THE ARCHIVES

Playground equipment on the Marina

SEPTEMBER 22, 1944

Work has begun to provide playgrounds for children and adults on the foreshore of the Marina. Playground equipment for games like football and basketball is proposed. Commissioner Mr.J.P.L. Shenoy is also contemplating the utilisation of the available open spaces in the city for this purpose and fitting them with playground equipment. There is also a proposal to open a swimming bath for children in the Napier Park.

WHAT’S GOING ON



Madras Photo Bloggers, Rotary Club of Chennai Crown, Deaf Artists Collective: Art Show, Visual Vernacular, Higginbothams, Anna Salai, 11 a.m.

Heritage IIT-M: Talk by K.R.A. Narasiah on ‘A Forest in the City’, Heritage Centre, Administration Block, IIT-Madras, 5 p.m.

VANISHING THEATRES

In 1964, the Madras State saw two 70mm theatres in fairly close succession, but the one to stake its claim as “the first 70mm theatre of South India” was **Anand Theatre** on Mount Road. It was inaugurated by former Chief Minister K. Kamaraj on August 22, 1964. About two days later, its inaugural film, the historical drama *El Cid* premiered, drawing notable personalities, including M. Bhaktavatsalam, then Chief Minister of the Madras State. For film buffs, Anand was more of a ritual where they went to watch English films. *Read the full story on newsth.live/anand.*

Chennai’s coast: the biggest open-air arena that entertains all

Zubeda Hamid
CHENNAI

For centuries, the answer to ‘What do we do now?’ posed by restless children, bored teenagers, and crotchety senior citizens in Madras to their family and friends must have been, ‘Let’s go to the beach’. Chennai’s long, winding coastline offers the city its biggest open-air, free entertainment zone – a democratised space of salt, sea breezes, and *sundal* – where one doesn’t have to search for entertainment.

The coastline is rich in its offerings. One loose



Mirth at Marina: The city’s beaches offer boundless entertainment, from film screenings to horse rides and play areas. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

bookend to the south is DakshinaChitra in Muttukadu. Begun as a project of the Madras Craft Foundation in the 1980s, it opened to the public in 1996, show-

casing South Indian art and culture – a veritable treasure trove to explore and shop. For those with a stronger inclination towards nature, the northern

bookend, Pulicat, with boat rides and the thrill of spotting a migratory bird, may be the way to go.

For about three decades from 1991, Chennaiites had the luxury of an open-air theatre: the Prarthana drive-in theatre in Injambakkam, which permanently closed in 2023. However, that did not stop films from being screened on the sands, alongside concerts, musical shows, poetry readings, and events, big and small.

The water offers boundless entertainment as well. While swimming is prohibited on Chennai’s beaches

due to dangerous undercurrents, the coast offers numerous water sports to choose from – boating in the backwaters, surfing in Kovalam, eFoiling, kayaking, sailing, stand-up paddling, and wakeboarding.

But the best of pleasures could be found on the beach itself. There’s something about the water lapping the sand that’s magical. Even on a damp weekday evening, there is no dearth of people at Marina Beach. A father and daughter towel themselves dry after a quick dip in the ocean; children frolic about on the playground

equipment while younger tots dig furiously in the sand, filling buckets; ponies whinny and paw the sand while their owners seek riders; balloon shooters set up their stalls; and merry-go-rounds whirr around to the accompaniment of delighted shrieks.

For 13-year-old M. Divya and her friend, the beach is the place to be, even if it involves travelling from their home in Puzhal.

There is something on offer for everyone: toddlers wave around bubble wands, children fling frisbees and play sports, adults scroll through their

phones or leaf through books, and the elderly lounge on benches, simply watching the world go by.

Mornings are filled with activity – Chennai’s famously energetic walkers, yoga and exercise classes, and sports practices abound as the city wakes up for its first cup of filter coffee. But evenings are the best – just when the sun begins to sink, the sands turn golden, and the whiff of reheated coffee in steel canteens permeates the air. As D.M. Dhyanes, 10, puts it, when asked what he likes about the Marina, “It’s just the sea”.

झारखण्ड शिक्षा परियोजना परिषद्
जे.एस.सी.ए. स्टेडियम रोड, सेक्टर-३, धुर्वा, राँची - 834004
दूरभाष:- 0651-2444501, 2444502, ई-मेल: jepcranchi1@gmail.com
Letter No. SOE/16/15/2025/3361 Date : 21.08.2026

Expression of Interest
JEPC invites Expression of Interest (EOI) from reputed, experienced, and competent EdTech organizations, academic service providers, and institutions of national standing to submit proposals and deliver technical presentations/demonstrations of their academic delivery model, live tutoring framework, diagnostic/adaptive assessment engine, doubt resolution mechanism, and digital learning platforms which may be infused across the State's 80 CM Schools of Excellence within the budget limit approved under Adarsh Vidyalaya Yojna. Interested firms can submit their proposal in the prescribed format to jepcranchi1@gmail.com by **31/08/2026**. The details format of proposal can be seen in website. jepc.jharkhand.gov.in.

Sd/-
(Shashi Ranjan)
State Project Director
Jharkhand Education Project Council

PR 388490 Jharkhand Education Project Council(26-27)#D

कार्यपालक अभियन्ता का कार्यालय
ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमण्डल, गिरिडीह

शुद्धि पत्र
PR No-386945 से प्रकाशित निविदा सूचना संख्या- RDD/SD/GIRIDIH/02/2026-27 में आंशिक संशोधन किया जाता है, जो निम्नवत् है:-

क्र० सं०	विवरण	पूर्व निर्धारित तिथि	संशोधित तिथि
1	वेबसाईट पर निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि	दि०-17.08.2026	31.08.2026
2	ई०-निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि	दि०-07.09.2026	10.09.2026
3	निविदा खोलने की तिथि	दि०-09.09.2026	12.09.2026

अन्य शर्तें यथावत् रहेंगे।

कार्यपालक अभियन्ता
ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमण्डल
गिरिडीह

PR 388554 Rural Development(26-27).D

Urban Development & Housing Department
1st Floor, Vikas Bhawan, New Secretariat, Patna - 800015
Phone: 0612-2215580 | Fax: 2217059 | Email: urbansec-bih@nic.in
०९ / नवंबर (सिविच) - 11 / 2026 - ९०३०

TENDER CANCELLATION NOTICE
PR No. 007250 (Urban) 2026-27
Due to unavoidable reasons, the Request for Proposal (RFP) invited for **"Retender (Group 3)- Request for Proposal for Selection of Consultant for the Preparation of Town Planning Scheme(s) for the Multiple Greenfield Satellite Townships in Bihar "** bearing PR No. 007250 (Urban) 2026-27 and NIT no-6903 is hereby cancelled.

(Prabhat Bhushan)
Officer on Special Duty
Urban Development and Housing Department

PR- 010657 (Urban) 2026-27
For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार

WESTERN RAILWAY - AHMEDABAD
(SURVEY AND CONSTRUCTION)
REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL FOR : PROVIDING PROJECT GENERAL MANAGEMENT SERVICES FOR VARIOUS WORKS
E-TENDER NOTICE No. CAO-C-ADI-PGMS-WR-01
By, Chief Engineer (Construction)-III, Western Railway, Ahmedabad for and on behalf of President of Union of India issued E-Tender Notice as under:

1	Name of work with its location: Request for Proposal (RFP) for : Providing Project General Management Services for New line, Multitracking, Gauge Conversion, Electrification and other important works etc. in Construction Organization under CAO/CADI of Western Railway, for a period of 60 months.	
2	Approx. cost of the work	₹ 406,73,28,000.00
3	Earnest money to be deposited	₹ 8,13,46,600.00
4	Completion Period	60 (Sixty) Months
5	Bid Due Date	07-10-2026 at 15:00 Hrs.
6	Physical submission of Original Documents as per KIT	upto 06-10-2026 upto 18:00 Hrs.
7	Opening of Technical Bid	07-10-2026 at 15:30 Hrs.
8	Pre-Bid Conference	11-09-2026 at 12:00 Hrs.
9	System of Tender	Two Packet System
10	Website particulars Notice Board location where complete details of tender can be seen & address of the office.	Web Site : www.ireps.gov.in Office of Dy. Chief Engineer (Construction)III, Western Railway, 2nd Floor, "A" Wing, Nirman Bhavan, Opp. GCS Hospital, Asarva, Ahmedabad-382345.

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CPM-062

CASAGRANT
Presenting
Made Of Chennai
PHOTO QUIZ
THE HINDU GROUP
Co-powered by

Seen here being performed by Ponnuswamy's troupe, this traditional Tamil folk theatre takes its name from the Tamil words for "street" and "theatre/play". What is this performance form called?

Answer to yesterday's Photo quiz:
Chitti Babu

Yesterday's winners:
1. Ahamed Jarith
2. Raghul J
3. Nandhini Krishnan

Scan QR code or visit newsth.live/MOC2026PA to take the Photo quiz. Top 3 winners* every day win gift vouchers.

*T&C apply.

 GOVERNMENT OF TAMIL NADU DIRECTORATE OF BACKWARD CLASSES WELFARE CHENNAI- 600 005	
e-Tender Notice No.01/2026-27	Dated:26.08.2026
e-TENDER NOTICE - INVITING TENDER UNDER FIXED RATE CONTRACT FROM MANUFACTURERS OF MODERN BICYCLES ALONG WITH HELMET AND WATER BOTTLE FOR SCHOOL GIRLS AND BOYS WITHIN INDIA	
For and on behalf of the Government of Tamil Nadu, Online e-Tenders are invited under fixed rate contract for the supply of School Girls and Boys' Modern Bi-cycles along with Helmet and water bottle under Two Cover System from the reputed Bi-cycle Manufacturing Firms within the Union of India. The firms should conform to IS Specifications (IS No. 10613: 2023 or latest) as specified in the Tender Document and have valid ISO certification and capacity to deliver the Modern Bi-cycles along with Helmet and Water Bottle as per the requirements.	
DETAILS OF e-TENDER NOTICE No. 01/2026-27	
Tender inviting Officer/ Authority Designation Address	The Director, Directorate of Backward Classes Welfare, Ezhilagam Annexe Building, 2nd floor, Chepauk, Chennai-600 005, Tamil Nadu.
Description of item	Procurement of approximately 2,37,133 numbers of School Boys Modern Bi-cycles along with Helmet and Water bottle and 2,95,255 numbers of School Girls' Modern Bi-cycles along with Helmet and Water bottle. Total 5,32,388 number of Modern Bi-cycles along with Helmet and Water bottle to be supplied for the year 2026-27.
Period of supply	150 days from the date of receipt of Purchase Order.
Earnest Money Deposit	Rs.70,00,000/- (Rupees Seventy Lakh only) payment should be made only through online.
Tender documents available for obtaining e-Tender	For free download of Tender document and for further details please visit the tender document portal https://intenders.gov.in e-tender should be submitted only through Online mode.
Period of submission of e-Tender	From 29.08.2026 to 28.09.2026 at 3.00 PM through online mode at https://intenders.gov.in
Date, Time and place of Pre-bid meeting	On 08.09.2026 at 11:00 AM , in the Conference Hall of Directorate of Backward Classes Welfare, Ezhilagam Annexe Building, 2nd floor, Chepauk, Chennai-600 005, Tamil Nadu.
Submission of two Sample Modern Bicycles (one girl and one Boy), Date, Time, Place and Officer.	28.09.2026 upto 05.00 PM THE DIRECTOR, Directorate of Backward Classes Welfare, Ezhilagam Annexe Building, 2nd floor, Chepauk, Chennai-600 005, Tamil Nadu.
Date, time and place of Opening of Technical Bid of the e-tender	On 29.09.2026 at 11:30 AM through online mode at https://intenders.gov.in
DIRECTOR, BACKWARD CLASSES WELFARE.	
DIPR/2677/Tender/2026	

	KARUR CITY MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
	Azad Road, Bunglow Street, Karur-639001.
	E-mail: commr.karur@tn.gov.in

**Notice inviting Tender through e-Tender National Competitive Bidding
Roc.No. E5/6052/2025, Dated.25.08.2026**

e-bids are invited from the eligible bidders for the following work as per the procedure under **two cover system** conforming to Tamil Nadu Transparency in Tenders Act, 1998 and Rules 2000

Sl. No.	Name of work and Estimate Amount.	Bid Security	Pre bid meeting date	e-bid submission closing date	e-bid Opening date
1.	Request for Proposal for appointment of Project Management Consultant (PMC) to implement Water Supply Improvement Scheme to Karur City Municipal Corporation. Estimate Amount Rs.411.40 Lakhs	Rs.41.1 Lakhs	09.09.2026 at 11.00 am	21.09.2026 upto 3.30 pm	21.09.2026 after 3.30 pm
2.	EMD by online transfer only through NIC portal. The tenderer shall submit scanned copy of online transaction statement towards EMD as part of technical bid. These forms to be registered with MS&C or considered as startups with appropriate registration documents will be exempted from the submission of EMD.				
3. Availability of tender documents and e-bid submission is permitted through tender portal/website: www.tenders.gov.in . For all other details refer tender schedule in the website from 05.09.2025					

Commissioner,
Karur City Municipal Corporation

Dipr/2680/Tenders/2026

FORM 4
(Under Section 82, 83 Cr.P.C.)

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING
THE APPEARANCE OF PERSON ACCUSED**

**IN THE COURT OF SPECIAL COURT
(Economic Offence - I), EGMORE, CHENNAI - 8.**

E.O.C.C. NO.04/2026

WHEREAS the complaint has been made before me that accused **A3.Mr.M.D.Karthikeyan** has committed the offences u/s. 132 and 135 of the Customs Act, 1962 as amended and section 120B of the Indian Penal Code and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **A3.Mr.M.D.Karthikeyan** cannot be found, and there it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **A3.Mr.M.D.Karthikeyan** has absconded or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said Non-Bailable warrant.

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **A3.Mr.M.D.Karthikeyan** is required to appear at **10.00 a.m.**, before the **Special Court, Economic Offences - I** at Egmore, Chennai - 600 008 to answer the said complaint on **30.09.2026**.

Given under my hand the seal of the court, this the **17th day of August 2026**.

Name and address of the Accused
A3.Mr.M.D.Karthikeyan,
S/o. Shri Durai,
No.145/1, Sundaram Pillai Nagar,
4th Street, Tondiarpet, Chennai - 81.

**District Judge/ACJM, Special Court (E.O.I),
Egmore, Chennai - 08.**

 TAMIL NADU GREEN ENERGY CORPORATION LIMITED Notice Inviting Tenders (E-tendering Process)		
Specification No	Tender Inviting Authority	Name of Work
HE - 2525	CE / HYDRO	E-Tender for engaging of 21 nos. of Computer operator / Data Entry operator through outsourcing for various offices under control of TNCECL / Headquarters, Chennai – 2
For Details of Work / Service / Due date of Submission / Opening / Viewing and down loading of E-Tenders Please visit Websites from https://tntenders.gov.in / tntenders.gov.in/nicgp/acep for submission of bids.		DIPR/2682/Tender/2026

 **Government of Tamil Nadu**
DEPARTMENT OF INFORMATION AND PUBLIC RELATIONS,

TENDER NOTICE

Tender No: 15112459/Memorials/2026, dated.28.08.2026.

Tenders are invited from reputed agencies for providing Security, Housekeeping, Gardening, Electrical and Plumbing services at Bharat Ratna Puratchi Thalaivar Dr.M.G.R memorial, Puratchi Thalaivi Selvi J Jayalalithaa memorial, Kalaiavan Arangam,Valluvar Kottam, Quaid-e millath memorial, Nadigar Thilagam Shivaji Ganesan memorial, Annal Ambedkar memorial, Bharathiyar Illam and Gandhi Mandapam Memorials in Chennai Region for a period of Two years. The tender documents could be downloaded from the website www.tntenders.gov.in at free of cost. Pre Bid Meeting - 08.09.2026 03.30 PM and last date for submission of tender - 15.09.2026 upto 03.30 PM. All other details are available in the website www.tntenders.gov.in

Director of Information and Public Relations
Secretariat, Chennai-600 009

DIPR/2691/TENDER/2026

In Partnership with





THE HINDU GROUP

Come for the beats. Stay for the feast.

The much-awaited food and music festival by *The Hindu's* **Made of Chennai** is finally here. From flavours that define our city to the beats that keep it moving - the mass combo that makes Chennai, Chennai is here to take over. Come savour the food, groove to the music and soak in the spirit of the city, all in one unforgettable evening.

August 29, 2026
4 PM onwards
YMCA Nandanam

FREE ENTRY WITH REGISTRATION

40+ FOOD STALLS
5+ HOURS OF MUSIC



Chinmayi Sripada



Paal Dabba



Antony Dassan



MAKKA Live



Vihara - The Band

CASAGRANT
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Presents

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FOOD AND MUSIC FESTIVAL

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Scan the QR or visit newsth.live/MOC2026PA to register.

<u>Consultant – 02 posts</u>	<u>Part Time – 02 posts</u>
1. Project Consultant (Civil) – 01 Post	1. Surgical Specialist – 01 post
2. Consultant (Senior Research Officer – Stat) 01 Post	2. Traditional Bone Setter – 01 post
<u>Consultant (Full time or Part time) – 01 Post</u>	
1. Medical Oncologist – 01 Post	
Note : For detailed information regarding the above posts, educational qualifications, age, experience, and general conditions, candidates are requested to visit the "NOTIFICATIONS" section of the Institute website (https://nischennai.org). Any updates or modifications regarding this recruitment will be posted only on the Institute website. Sd/- Director	

CM
YK

INBRIEF



Bevco records liquor sales of ₹771.29 cr. during Onam week

The Kerala State Beverages Corporation (Bevco) clocked liquor sales of ₹771.29 crore during the eight days leading up to Onam till August 25. The corresponding figure during the previous year was ₹694.9 crore, its Managing Director told *The Hindu*. The highest daily sales of ₹132.87 crore during the period was recorded on August 24, while the sales on August 25 was ₹126.34 crore. The sales figures for Uthradom were lower compared to the previous year's ₹137.64 crore.

Comic Con India to be held in Visakhapatnam in October

Comic Con India will make its Andhra Pradesh debut in Visakhapatnam on October 10 and 11, marking the start of its 2026-27 season. The event will be held at the Kalam Convention Centre. Shefali Johnson, CEO of Comic Con India, said Visakhapatnam's association with Telugu cinema is being complemented by growing interest in anime, cosplay and student communities. The event will feature international guests, cosplay showcases, interactive sessions and fan zones.

Auto driver ends life alleging MVD harassment in Keralam

An autorickshaw driver from Mundapparamba in Malappuram district in Keralam ended his life on Thursday after alleging harassment by Motor Vehicles department (MVD) officials. The Transport department has ordered an inquiry into the incident. Shoukath, 35, left a note on Facebook shortly before his death. He alleged that MVD officials refused to renew the fitness certificate of his auto-rickshaw because he had not paid bribes. (*Tele MANAS helpline - 14416*)

Shivakumar meets Cong. brass amid Nagendra row

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU/ NEW DELHI/ KALABURAGI

Amid the Opposition demand for the resignation of Planning and Statistics Minister B. Nagendra, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar met the party's Central leadership in Delhi on Thursday. The Opposition has accused Mr. Nagendra of embezzling funds from the Mahārshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribe Development Corporation. Mr. Kharge dismissed the speculation regarding an imminent Cabinet reshuffle or organisational changes.

How A.P.'s Gattumeedapalle turned into a 'ghost village'

K. Umashanker
MADANAPALLE

Seven hairpin bends above Kosuvaripalle panchayat in Andhra Pradesh's Annamayra district, the tar road comes to an abrupt end. At the top of a 200-foot hillock is Gattumeedapalle village. It has streetlights that burn every evening, a village temple, and an elementary school. However, no one resides here. All 60 houses are empty, surrounded by an eerie silence, only disturbed by wind across the hillock. Once home to 60 joint families and around 500 people, this hamlet is now a textbook case of silent rural collapse. Gattumeedapalle was



A deserted street in Gattumeedapalle village.

once known for its groundnut cultivation. When the monsoons were favourable, each household harvested 200 bags. "The trouble started in the 1980s. Rains failed monsoon after monsoon. Our people dug borewells in dozens, but all

failed," says Ramasubba Reddy, who left the village in early 2000. "Though we had drinking water, there was not any for crops," he says. With the decline in cultivation, the village economy got hit and migration started. In the 1990s, one family climbed down the hillock and settled in Kosuvaripalle, the immediate downhill panchayat. Others followed. Just before the 2024 elections, a tar road was laid to the top of the hillock. "None of us asked any official for a road, which sounds like a big joke to us," says a former resident. "No official is bothered to look into the core of the village's predicament," he added.

Voice behind many revolutionary songs, comes home to a place of her own at 95

Hiran Unnikrishnan
KOTTAYAM

"Red Salute" is an album of revolutionary songs that became synonymous with veteran singer P.K. Medini, whose voice has echoed from Left platforms across Kerala since she was 13. Nearly eight decades later, the 95-year-old communist has found a permanent address of her own at Thottakam, near Vaikom, the native place of communist leader P. Krishna Pillai. Fittingly, she has named her new home "Red Salute". Medini *chechi*, as she is popularly known, had spent the past eight years in rented houses at Manancherry, Alappuzha. Her wish for a home of her own



The house built for the revolutionary singer P.K. Medini (inset) at Vaikom. THULASI KAKKAT

became a reality after the CPI State leadership asked its Vaikom mandalam committee to help her settle in the land associated with Krishna Pillai. The house has come up on a 5.5-cent plot near the Vaikom Vechoor road. The plot was purchased for ₹10

lakh, while the CPI spent ₹15 lakh to build the 600-sq ft house, which was completed in 62 days, said V.B. Binu, a member of the CPI State committee. Ms. Medini chose the name "Red Salute", a tribute to the song associated with her for decades. CPI

State secretary Binoy Viswam will hand over the keys to Medini at a function here on Thursday evening. "This is the biggest award the communist movement has ever given me," she said. "I regard this as a memorial to the Communist Party and wish to develop it into an art and cultural centre. I am happy to accommodate here anyone who is struggling for food," added the veteran communist. Anyone in need who comes to 'Red Salute', she said, would be offered drinking water and a share of their food. She also dedicated the name of her house to the countless communists who sacrificed their lives for the movement in Kerala.

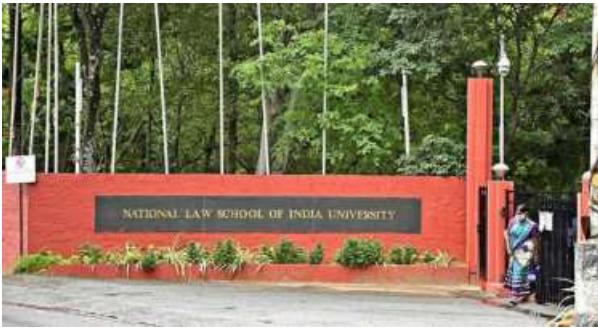
NLSIU cancels convocation amid protests over CJI invite

Varsity cites 'unavoidable circumstances', says graduates can collect degree certificate from office or get it through courier; students and alumni were against inviting CJI and BCI chief to the event

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The National Law School of India University (NLSIU), Bengaluru, has cancelled its convocation ceremony for the graduating students of 2026.

In a letter dated August 27, a copy of which is with *The Hindu*, the Registrar said: "On August 3, the academic administration team emailed graduating students, with advance notice, informing them that September 12 was the proposed date for the annual convocation. Despite our collective best efforts, we are unable to hold the 34th Annual Convocation due



NLSIU students had expressed solidarity with NALSAR students, and sought the BCI's apology. FILE PHOTO

to unavoidable circumstances." "All students will be conferred their degrees *in absentia* after due approval by the governing bodies. Students may elect to receive their certificates by courier or collect them on

campus," the letter said. The decision came after graduating students and alumni of NLSIU wrote to the administration on August 15, opposing the invitation extended to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Bar Council of In-

dia (BCI) chairman Manan Kumar Mishra for the convocation. The letter opposing the invitation was signed by 165 graduating students, 409 current students, and 128 alumni.

The letter was in support of Hyderabad's NALSAR University of Law students and faculty, and had sought the BCI's apology. The BCI chief had directed the State Bar Council not to enrol NALSAR students after they opposed the presence of the Chief Justice at their convocation.

When contacted, NLSIU told *The Hindu* that "no student will suffer any adverse consequences arising out of the decision not to hold a convocation".

Seven killed as bus hits auto in A.P. town

Sambasiva Rao M.
CHILAKALURIPET

Seven people were killed, and eight sustained injuries when a private bus rammed an autorickshaw at Addaroad Centre in Chilakaluripet town of Palnada district, Andhra Pradesh, on Thursday. Fifteen people, all from Veluru village in Chilakaluripet mandal, had travelled in the autorickshaw to Konada Manjularu village in J. Panguluru mandal of Pra-

kasam district, the police said. While returning to Veluru, the autorickshaw was taking a turn at Addaroad Centre when it was hit by a private travel bus travelling from Vijayawada to Tirupati. Four people died on the spot, while another person died while undergoing treatment at the Chilakaluripet Government Hospital. Two more people died due to the injuries at the Government General Hospital in Guntur.

Forest officials to face custodial torture trial

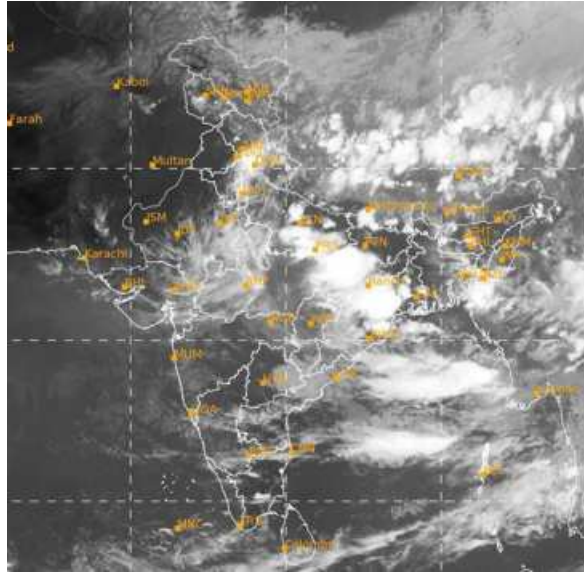
K.S. Sudhi
KOCHI

Eight Forest Department officials from Keralam will face trial for custodial torture, over a decade after the alleged incident. The accused include an IFS couple. Last week, the Chief Judicial Magistrate Court, Thiruvananthapuram, ordered the prosecution of IFS officers T. Uma; her husband, R. Kamalahar; and six forest officials on a

complaint from Aji Brait, an accused in the Malayattoor elephant poaching case in 2015, alleging illegal detention and torture, resulting in severe injuries. Mr. Brait had moved the court after the State Forest department refused sanction to prosecute the officials. However, the court held that prosecution sanction was not required in the case as the alleged acts bore no reasonable connection with the performance of official duties.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



Forecast for Friday:				Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Assam, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Odisha, Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh. Thunderstorm with lightning & gusty winds likely at isolated places over Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu and Puducherry			
CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		36.5	27.0	Kurnool		0.2	35.0
Ahmedabad		33.7	26.8	Lucknow		14.3	34.1
Aizawl		24	31.8	Madurai		39.0	26.6
Bengaluru		28.2	20.8	Mangaluru		21.9	29.1
Bhopal		24.2	25.2	Mumbai		31.7	26.6
Bhubaneswar		52	34.6	Mysuru		4	26.0
Chandigarh		35.9	25.4	New Delhi		34.9	27.2
Chennai		36.0	27.7	Patna		10.2	35.4
Coimbatore		32.6	22.6	Port Blair		18.9	29.3
Dehradun		30.5	23.7	Prayagraj		2.2	34.0
Gangtok		24	35.8	Puducherry		37.6	27.8
Goa		24	31.6	Pune		29.4	22.0
Guwahati		32.6	26.7	Raipur		29.3	24.6
Hubballi		28.0	22.0	Ranchi		1	30.3
Hyderabad		12	31.2	Shillong		11	25.6
Imphal		0.2	30.1	Shimla		5	24
Jaipur		22	35.3	Srinagar		32.9	18.2
Kochi		0.6	30.2	Thiruvananthapuram		20.1	30.7
Kohima		26.0	21.0	Tiruchirappalli		39.7	28.0
Kolkata		0.1	35.1	Vijayawada		33.6	27.2
Kozhikode		13.9	32.6	Visakhapatnam		35.0	27.6

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)				Yesterday			
Pollutants in the air you are breathing				In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Bhiwani			
CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE	
Ahmedabad		9	43	66		133	
Bengaluru		12	89	42		10	72
Chennai		8	14	34		92	100
Delhi		39	43		226	353	
Hyderabad		9	13	34		46	69
Kochi		5	30	41		79	90
Lucknow		30	32	14		34	43
Mumbai		8	7	35		29	183
Pune		9	19	71		36	91
Visakhapatnam		16	71	10		58	119

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

‘Withdraw polytechnic merger with YISC’

The Hindu Bureau
HANAMKONDA

BRS Legislature Party deputy leader T. Harish Rao has alleged that the Congress government in Telangana was trying to stifle the voice of polytechnic students protesting against its arbitrary move to merge polytechnic education

with the Young India Skill University (YISU) through G.O. 97. Mr. Rao was speaking to a group of students of the Warangal Government Polytechnic college who met him in Hanamkonda on Thursday. Earlier, Mr. Rao was detained by the police while he was on his way to the

protest site of the polytechnic students. Mr. Rao alleged that Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy was jeopardising the academic careers of polytechnic students by issuing G.O. 97, which, he claimed, was detrimental to polytechnic education. He said merging government polytechnic colleges

with the Skill University, established under the "public-private partnership", amounted to "virtually privatising" the colleges. Mr. Rao questioned why Congress leader Rahul Gandhi was not visiting Telangana when polytechnic students were agitating. He also sought immediate withdrawal of G.O. 97.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

B. KRISHNA BABU (68), Retired Foreman (Non Supervisory), Canteen Dept., The Hindu Chennai passed away on 26.08.2026. Address: 886 LG I Phase III TNHB MG Nagar Ambattur Chennai - 600058. Ct: 99625 91365.

SMT.G.SUSILA (82), Mother of Mrs. Tara Kannan Chennai - 600078, expired on 26.08.2026. Eyes donated to Rotary Rajan Eye Bank (Project of Rotary Club of Madras T.Nagar), Chennai-17.(Ph: 28340500)



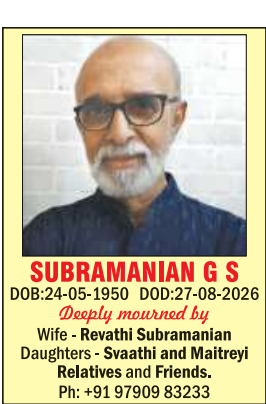
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DEATH



Mr. R. ILAVARASAN (74 yrs) Retired CFO of Madras University DOB: 01-10-1951 - DOD: 26-08-2026 Funeral will be held on 28-08-2026 between 11am to 1.30pm
Deeply Mourned by
S.Vinod Kumar & R.I Anusha I.Navin & Indrani Navin Mrs.R.Kayarkanni & Mr.G.S.Selvaratharasu Dr.Ezhilarasan Ramanan & Mrs. E.Santhi Family Members. Ph: 8861033008

DEATH



SUBRAMANIAN G S DOB:24-05-1950 DOD:27-08-2026
Deeply mourned by
Wife - Revathi Subramanian Daughters - Svathi and Maitreyi Relatives and Friends. Ph: +91 97909 83233

DEATH



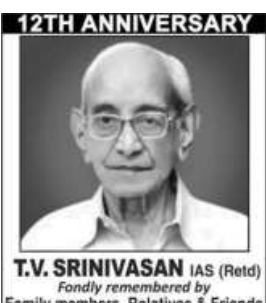
G RAJALAKSHMI 28th JULY 1941 - 25th AUGUST 2026
With profound sorrow, we announce the passing of our beloved G Rajalakshmi, devoted wife of TS Gopalakrishnan, who left for her heavenly abode on 25th August 2026. A treasured wife, loving mother, adored grandmother, and proud great-grandmother, she lived a life filled with grace and devotion.
IN GRIEF
Sathyanarayanan & Shobana Kala Prabhu
Fondly Remembered By, Pavi, Shiva & Rudra Chari & Yura Sune & Sibi Praveen, Sanju & Jai Hini, Gayu & Veda
CONTACT
Sathyanarayanan (Son) +91 98403-5865

DEATH



It is with profound grief that we announce that our beloved father,
Shri K. V. Balram Rao
Retired Executive Engineer, TNEB attained Acharyan Thiruvadi on Monday, 24 August 2026.
Deeply mourned by
Son: Sanjay Balram (9186616108)
Daughter-in-law: Rtn. Archana Sanjay (9840079489)
Loving nieces, nephews and grandchildren
Shrinidhi, 22 Co-operative Colony, Alwarpet, Chennai - 600018

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES



T.V. SRINIVASAN IAS (Retd)
Fondly remembered by Family members, Relatives & Friends



Danger from above

Natural outbursts in hilly terrain are rising amid climate change

Disaster struck Nepal on Wednesday after a flash flood ravaged the Himalayas and foothills. As of Thursday, at least 359 people including several foreign tourists, had died, while at least 300 Indians remained missing. Satellite imagery analysed by global agencies, including the Indian Space Research Organisation, points to a glacier collapse or ice-rock avalanche in Tibet, possibly followed by a temporary river blockage and its sudden failure. An earthquake was initially suspected, but evidence has not borne it out. While the immediate flood wave has passed, there are warnings of possible secondary flooding from debris blockages upstream. There has been extensive damage along the Bhoté Koshi and Trishuli corridors, with settlements washed away and hydropower and monitoring infrastructure damaged. Nepalese authorities said 35 motorable and 45 suspension bridges and about 40 kilometres of roads had been damaged.

Given that it is the monsoon, north India and the larger Himalayan regions are under the influence of a powerful Western Disturbance. It would thus not have been unreasonable to attribute the floods to these extratropical storms that can cause clouds to collide with mountains and release enormous quantities of rain at short notice. But the ubiquity of satellites is helping establish a more complex picture, pointing to collapsing glaciers and recalling the October 2023 South Lhonak Lake disaster in Sikkim. There, an eponymous Himalayan glacier suddenly gave way, releasing millions of tonnes of water, debris and rock that pulverised Sikkim's largest hydropower project. Subsequent analysis showed that the resulting Glacial Lake Outburst Flood (GLOF) had been years in the making. The Indian Himalayas have nearly 7,500 glacial lakes and about 15,000 glaciers, some monitored through remote sensing. Yet, fully assessing their condition requires site visits, difficult because these lakes lie in inhospitable terrain while expeditions are generally feasible only from July to September. Even with satellite monitoring, accurately forecasting a glacier collapse remains exceedingly difficult – and can be counterproductive if warnings trigger panic among residents who, often because of habit or lack of alternatives, are unlikely to move out of harm's way. Dams and hydropower projects in such terrain are often among the first casualties of these natural outbursts, which are increasing amid global warming. Beyond relief and rescue, governments must enforce construction codes, discourage settlements and large projects in known vulnerable zones, and invest in better tracking of glacier health. Such monitoring can feed long-term disaster planning into development programmes. A tragedy is frequently not the result of a conspiracy but the product of passive neglect; the latter can be addressed.

New-age fires

Fire accidents in ICUs need better and more evacuation facilities

Not too long ago, India's fire accidents typically occurred in industrial facilities, large offices, mass gatherings, firecracker units and railway compartments, caused by faulty machinery, weak safety procedures and careless use of flammable materials. While these risks persist, what has got added to the country's poor record in fire safety in the last 15 years or so is residential buildings, hotels and hospitals, especially Intensive Care Units (ICU). Electrical fires now seem predominant, often caused by increased appliance use, overloaded electrical systems and poor maintenance. ICUs are especially vulnerable with their oxygen-rich environments. This month, back-to-back accidents at neonatal ICUs in Amravati, Maharashtra, and Chhindwara, Madhya Pradesh, claimed the most vulnerable: newborn babies. The Amravati fire was put out in 30 minutes, but the smoke was too much for the three babies admitted because of complications. A faulty ventilator is suspected to be the cause. In the NICU at Chhindwara District Hospital, a short circuit in a warmer triggered a fire and three babies, just days old, suffered burns. Over the past 15 years, ICU fires, including the one in Jhansi in 2024, in which 18 newborns died, have not served as a wake-up call. The Amravati fire shared many features with previous incidents.

Perhaps the best way to respond to these new-age fires would be to treat ICU accidents as a distinct category. ICUs are sealed compartments where smoke fills up very quickly. In an NICU, where patients cannot self-evacuate, evacuation drills are essential. A best-case setup would have three independent exits, with at least two allowing horizontal evacuation, automatic sprinklers, independent power lines for large equipment, oxygen cylinder bed supports, and fire drills every two years. A well-designed ICU also locates oxygen outlets away from sockets. Following a Delhi NICU fire, the National Neonatology Forum called for mandatory fire safety certification for NICU-equipped hospitals, regular power audits, analogue addressable alarms, and an evacuation protocol – now RACE or Rescue, Alarm, Confine, Extinguish/Evacuate. The 2026 National Guidelines on Fire and Life Safety in Healthcare Facilities can be a useful starting point for ICU-NICU safety. Beyond all this lies an issue in power quality: electrical harmonics. NICU equipment is packed with electronic components that draw distorted current, which can silently overheat neutral wiring, transformers, and loose connections without tripping a breaker. Post-fire reports citing generic “short circuits” or “technical faults” may well be missing this harmonic-driven degradation, a largely unaudited risk factor.

Days after both Houses of Parliament were adjourned *sine die* on August 13, 2026, the monsoon session has yet to be formally prorogued. The delay has prompted speculation that Parliament could be reconvened for another attempt at the constitutional amendment linked to delimitation and women's reservation. Whether or not that happens, it gives urgency to a question Parliament must confront: must delimitation necessarily mean an enlargement of the Lok Sabha?

Numbers alone cannot decide

At first glance, the issue looks like arithmetic. India's population has grown enormously since Lok Sabha seats were frozen half a century ago, so it seems natural to argue that representation must now expand correspondingly. But, constitutional design is not arithmetic alone.

Article 81 requires representation broadly to correspond to population, “so far as practicable”, while Article 82 provides for readjustment after every Census. Yet, Parliament has twice modified the mechanical application of this principle when another compelling national objective was at stake. In 1976, through the 42nd Constitutional Amendment, the inter-State allocation of seats was frozen on the basis of the 1971 Census so that States successful in family planning were not politically penalised for reducing population growth. The freeze was later extended by the 84th Amendment until the publication of figures from the first Census conducted after 2026. Parliament thus recognised that population matters, but it is not the only constitutional value at stake.

The government has reportedly suggested increasing every State's representation by roughly 50%, arguing that this would leave each with the same ‘proportion’ of Lok Sabha seats that it has today. On the face of it, that appears to answer the fear of the southern States of losing their relative position. But ‘proportion’ tells only half the story.

Suppose Uttar Pradesh rises from 80 seats to 120, while Tamil Nadu rises from 39 to about 59. Their proportional relationship remains unchanged. Yet, the absolute gap in voting strength rises from 41 Members of Parliament (MP) to around 61. Parliament does not vote in proportions; it votes in absolute numbers. Governments are formed by numbers, and confidence motions, legislation, and constitutional amendments are decided by numbers. A 50% pro-rata increase may preserve the ratio while widening the numerical gap.

The 1976 freeze therefore embodied a federal compact: States that succeeded in population stabilisation would not see their political voice diminished for doing what national policy encouraged. That understanding should not now be thoughtlessly discarded.

There is also a misconception that delimitation and enlargement are inseparable. They are not. India has already shown that constituency boundaries can be redrawn without changing the



S.Y. Quraishi

Former Chief Election Commissioner of India and the author of ‘An Undocumented Wonder – The Making of the Great Indian Election’

Delimitation, federal fairness and women's representation can all be achieved without enlarging the Lok Sabha

Why 543 should remain 543

number of seats allocated to each State. The delimitation after the 2001 Census reorganised constituencies within States while maintaining the existing inter-State allocation.

That principle can be adopted again. The 2027 Census can provide the basis for redrawing constituencies within each State so that populations are more evenly distributed. Boundaries can reflect demographic movement and urbanisation. None of this requires increasing the Lok Sabha beyond 543 or disturbing the present federal balance.

A continuously expanding legislature is also not an inevitable consequence of population growth. The United States House of Representatives has remained at 435 voting members (there were some temporary exceptions) for more than a century despite enormous population growth. Switzerland's National Council has remained at 200 members since 1963. Going a step further, Hungary reduced its Parliament from 386 members to 199, while Italy reduced its Chamber of Deputies from 630 to 400. There is no democratic law requiring legislatures to grow whenever population grows.

Bigger House, weaker deliberation

There is another serious concern: what a larger House does to Parliament's own functioning. Parliamentary time does not expand with the number of MPs. Even with 543 members, many MPs hardly get opportunities to speak, ask questions or raise matters of public importance. A Lok Sabha enlarged by 50%, to more than 800 members, would reduce those opportunities further. It may increase representation numerically while weakening the quality of deliberation, one of Parliament's most important functions. Indian MPs already represent the largest average constituencies among the world's major democracies – several times the size of a U.S. congressional district or a U.K. constituency. Freezing the House at 543 while the population keeps growing means that burden only increases after delimitation, and the case for more representatives to improve accessibility is a real one. But it does not follow that the additional representatives must sit in Parliament. Most citizens approach elected representatives over roads, schools, hospitals, local services and State administration - matters substantially within the State sphere. If population growth has made constituencies unwieldy, strengthening representation at the State level is, therefore, a more sensible solution. More MLAs and smaller Assembly constituencies can bring representatives closer to citizens without continuously enlarging the national legislature.

That expansion faces none of the federal-arithmetic constraint that makes Lok Sabha expansion fraught. A larger Assembly shifts no balance between States – each answers only to its own population. Vidhan Sabhas can therefore grow to meet accessibility needs without disturbing the inter-State balance in Parliament that the 1976 freeze was designed to protect. Then comes women's reservation.

India's return to its Central Asian neighbourhood

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is set to travel to Central Asia in the next few days, the first port of call being a state visit to Uzbekistan, followed by participation in the meeting of Heads of State of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) in the Kyrgyz capital, Bishkek, called Frunze in Soviet times. The change of names is not just symbolic. It represents the birth of a new region.

Central Asia is an evocative moniker. The region lies landlocked, situated between two giants, Russia and China. In most of its countries, the post 1991 generation has largely taken over, engaged in finding a new internal equilibrium. Islam is the main religion, but does not define identity and is therefore not a political project. The fight against radicalisation and terrorism is uncompromising. Occasional catastrophes such as the devastating Crocus City Hall terror attack in Moscow in 2024, China's constant fear of spread of radicalisation in the border regions and export of instability and extremist ideology from Afghanistan are everyday reminders of the challenges.

In Central Asia, there are a multitude of ethnicities, languages, geographies and resource endowments. These influence domestic and foreign policy choices, with Turkmenistan practising rigorous neutrality. Relations among countries are complicated by legacy disputes over borders, water resources and overlapping ethnicities. Türkiye and Iran are dominant influences, while the United States and the European Union are working their way in as Russia's hold weakens and China's grows.

Mr. Modi's 2015 visit to all five Central Asian countries was historic. It marked the end of an unstated Indian policy of deferring to Russia in its periphery – politely keeping away. In 2017, India was welcomed into the SCO as a full member by Russia, as Pakistan was, by China. To mark the 30 years of their independence/diplomatic ties, India



Pankaj Saran

Former Deputy National Security Adviser, Ambassador and Convenor, NatStrat

The Prime Minister's visit is an opportunity for India to deepen its strategic presence, expand economic ties and strengthen its diplomatic influence

made an unprecedented gesture of inviting all Central Asian leaders as chief guests for the Republic Day in 2022. The COVID-19 pandemic forced the event to be held only virtually, but not without it leading to the creation of high-level mechanisms for cooperation, including the India-Central Asia Dialogue.

Beyond geography

If South Asia and West Asia, not to speak of East Asia and the Indian Ocean Region are India's neighbourhoods, Central Asia is no less. A lack of overland connectivity does not take away from the civilisational links India has with the region – in culture, religion, language and architecture. Geographically, India and Tajikistan are separated only by the narrow Wakhan corridor that lies in Afghanistan. India is part of the continuum that is the Eurasian landmass.

Pakistan, a historically new piece in the equation, seeks to usurp the historical lineage based on religious affinity. Its tactic to cut India off, physically and otherwise, from these historical connections, like its other India-centric gambits, is, as anecdotal evidence shows, doomed to failure. Yet, India must not allow this to succeed. Countries of the region are today looking beyond Russia and China for partners in their socio-economic development. India's lived experience as a plural, moderate and democratic society is admired not feared in the region.

It is against this background that Mr. Modi's decision to go back to the region must be welcomed. India should build upon the foundations to consolidate its rightful place in the region, whether in the economic, trade, defence, natural resources, technology spheres or in softer areas such as cultural, educational, health and tourism exchanges. The choice of a state visit to Uzbekistan is consistent with the steady improvement of relations under President Mirziyoyev since 2016. It is among the most

One-third reservation for women is now being connected with delimitation, and enlargement of the Lok Sabha is presented partly as a way of accommodating women without disturbing existing political interests.

But women's representation should not become a constitutional justification for enlarging the House. One-third of the present Lok Sabha is approximately 181 seats. Women can receive their constitutionally promised representation within the existing House of 543. The purpose of reservation is to alter who occupies parliamentary seats, not necessarily to create hundreds of additional ones.

A 50% expansion could produce a curious result: the number of women MPs would rise, which is desirable, but so would the numerical dominance of the already larger States. A reform intended to correct one representational imbalance could deepen another. Women's representation and federal fairness are both legitimate constitutional objectives. India need not choose between them.

Preserve 543, undertake reforms

The solution is simple: retain the Lok Sabha at 543; preserve the present inter-State distribution of seats; undertake delimitation within States on updated population figures; implement women's reservation within that structure; and expand the Vidhan Sabhas to absorb the accessibility pressure that population growth has created.

For half a century, States have pursued demographic policies knowing that successful population stabilisation would not reduce their parliamentary influence. Southern States in particular invested heavily in education, health care and family welfare and achieved fertility levels that national policy itself encouraged. To reward that success with a larger political advantage for States where population grew faster would invert the incentive the Union deliberately created.

The question, therefore, is not whether population should matter. Of course it should. The question is whether it should now mechanically rearrange the federal political balance that India consciously preserved for five decades. Twice before, Parliament amended the constitutional framework to preserve the existing inter-State allocation despite population changes. There is no reason it cannot do so a third time. The uncertainty over whether Parliament may be recalled makes this more than an academic debate. Decisions taken now could shape the federal balance of the Republic for decades.

Delimitation is necessary. Women's representation is overdue. Updated constituency boundaries are desirable. But none of these objectives requires an 800-plus-member Lok Sabha.

Sometimes constitutional wisdom lies not in making institutions larger, but in preserving the balance that has allowed them to endure; 543 has served India for more than half a century. There is a strong constitutional, federal and democratic case for letting this number remain 543.

dynamic countries of the region, and most forward in the diversification of its foreign policy. Any Indian visitor to Tashkent, Samarkand or Bukhara will vouch for the empathy and resonance between the two peoples.

There are also hardnosed reasons – Uzbekistan has been uncompromising in its fight against terrorism and extremism. Its intimate knowledge of Afghanistan, and pragmatic approach towards the Taliban, are of key importance to India. India has had detailed discussions with it on alternative rail and road connectivity routes through Iran and Afghanistan which need to be revisited in the light of recent developments in these countries.

India and the SCO

Starting from the small beginnings of the “Shanghai Five” in 1996, the SCO, in its 25th anniversary, has grown to 10 members, 15 dialogue partners and two observers. With the exception of 2024, Mr. Modi has been a regular participant in SCO Heads of States meetings. India's SCO engagement is driven by geography, not ideology. Within the SCO chambers, negotiating against a China-Pakistan dyad is demanding but essential. India has kept its head above the swamp by suggesting several ideas to enhance cooperation in the economic, technological and civilisational fields. In Tianjin last year, Mr. Modi put forward the vision of security, connectivity, and opportunity for the SCO. In the instant case, for a country as overwhelmingly dependent on China as Kyrgyzstan, the SCO, and India in particular, offers a valuable geopolitical lifeline.

Taken together with his visits to the Indian Ocean Region last month, Mr. Modi would have traversed far-flung corners of India's maritime and continental neighbourhood in quick succession reflecting India's geostrategic imperatives and opportunities.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A Himalayan disaster

Two major factors behind the Nepal disaster are its mountainous terrain and the intensity of the cloudburst or the melting of glaciers in the higher Himalayan ranges. The steep slopes would have

allowed gushing water to reach the plains quickly; they can also become death traps for those caught in sudden downstream flows. While the media is still trying to assess the toll, it is certain to run into the thousands. This particular

disaster is unprecedented in the scale of its destruction, with hundreds of villages and small towns wiped out. It is truly heartbreaking. **V. Lakshmanan**, Tirupur, Tamil Nadu

Post-disaster relief is no

longer enough. It is most essential that Himalayan nations must collaborate on joint early-warning networks, real-time data sharing, and resilient infrastructure. **Kshirasagara Balaji Rao**, Hyderabad

Revive cultural institution Tamil Nadu's apex cultural body, the Eyal Isai Nataka Mandram, is inactive, while the Kalaimamani State awards remain suspended. The TVK government should revive the institution, reconstitute its

executive/general councils, and reform the awards process by separating classical arts from cinema. **V.P. Dhananjayan**, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

States step up efforts to trace missing, stranded people after Nepal disaster

West Bengal launches efforts to find 32 pilgrims who travelled for Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra; former Union Minister Mukul Roy's daughter-in-law is part of the group; Isha Foundation in T.N. says pilgrim group of 80 from various countries missing; measures to bring back people being worked on

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

Officials of several States stepped up efforts to trace people missing or stranded after the devastating flash floods in Nepal, with Chief Ministers urging departments to coordinate to ensure prompt rescue measures. The State governments were also in touch with the Centre to bring back stranded residents.

In West Bengal, the focus was on a group of 32 people who had travelled for the Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra and remained untraceable. Among the 32, at least 21 are senior citizens, and many others are in their late 50s. Sharmistha Bhowmik Roy, daughter-in-law of former Union Minister Mukul Roy, is also part of the group.

“The Government of West Bengal is actively coordinating with the Embassy of India in Kathmandu and proper administrative channels,” Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari



Flood aftermath: Nepal army personnel comforting twin babies amid a search operation after the devastating flash floods at Trishuli camp; and Indian nationals, who were airlifted from Rasuwa district, sitting inside the Maithali Barrack in Nepal on Thursday. P.TI, REUTERS

posted on social media. The group had booked their trip with Cholo Jai, a travel agency in West Bengal, and started from Kolkata on August 21. Samrat Travels, their partner company, handles the Nepal portion of the trip.

Cholo Jai staff were not able to establish contact with the group. According to the agency, the group left their hotel in Nepal's Rasuwagadhi on Wednesday morning and headed towards the China border. Around 8.30 a.m., they went to the immigration of

fice in the same area to cross over to Tibet. Rasuwagadhi is one of the worst hit areas in the flash flood.

“Today morning, four managers from our company went there to get local information and further details about the rescue operations. We are constantly in touch with families,” Manish Singh, a Cholo Jai staffer, told presspersons. A film crew from Bengal is also stuck in Nepal. They are in a safe zone and accessible by phone.

In Tamil Nadu, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay directed Ministers and officials to oversee the rescue and safe return of people from the State. A total of 103 people from Tamil Nadu who had gone on a pilgrimage were stranded. Several of them were feared missing.



80 pilgrims missing Isha Foundation, based in Coimbatore in the State, said a pilgrim group with 80 members of several countries, was missing in the floods. The foundation has

reached out to the Embassies for authoritative information on the missing members, it added. In a video message from the Tibet side of the Chinese border, founder of Isha Foundation Sadhguru Jaggi Vasudev said the pilgrim group consisted of 34 men and 46 women.

The Keralam government confirmed that it received around 17 distress calls from families affected by the Nepal disaster. The government said it was trying to establish contact with the 53 stranded per-

sons from the State and ensure their safety.

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu directed officials to maintain round-the-clock vigil on the Nepal situation and ensure all possible assistance.

Sources said seven from the State were reported missing or stranded. Four pilgrims from Adoni and Kurnool were found to be safe and staying at a hotel in China, while efforts continued to locate three others.

The four traced pilgrims were part of a 156-member Kailash-Mansarovar group, they added.

The Telangana government said it had provisionally identified 23 residents of the State who were stranded in Nepal. The State government was coordinating with the External Affairs Ministry, the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu and Nepalese authorities. On Thursday, the Ministry said at least 290 Indian nationals remained “uncontactable” after the tragedy in Nepal.



Taking stock: Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary conducting an aerial survey of the flood situation in border areas. P.TI

Water levels subside in Bihar rivers; risk of flooding reduces

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

A day after a flash flood killed hundreds in Nepal and threatened to overflow into neighbouring Bihar, the risk of flooding in the Gandak, Ganga, and other tributary rivers subsided significantly on Thursday.

However, debris and cattle carcasses were seen in the Gandak river.

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary conducted an aerial survey of the Valmikinagar barrage areas of West Champaran district along the Indo-Nepal border which had faced an imminent threat till Thursday afternoon.

“The way disaster had struck Nepal is a matter of

concern. The Prime Minister and Union Home Minister were continuously keeping a close watch on Bihar,” he told presspersons. “The situation is gradually becoming normal... The discharge at the barrage was around 1 lakh cusecs today,” he added.

Fearing a flash flood in the Gandak, all 36 gates of the Valmikinagar barrage had been opened on Wednesday. The barrage started witnessing three-metre-high waves and the water gush peaked at 1.5 lakh cusecs on Thursday afternoon. It then “started decreasing”, one of the senior engineers said.

Water levels also receded in the Ganga river at some places in Patna.

U.P. activates rescue teams, focuses on monitoring rivers in border areas

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

In the wake of the flash floods in Nepal, the administrations of districts in Uttar Pradesh bordering the country said on Thursday that their focus remained on continuous river monitoring.

They focus was also on alerting vulnerable villages and keeping relief and rescue teams ready for any possible flood situation.

“Amid the floods and natural disaster in Nepal, the Uttar Pradesh government has taken charge, on the instructions of Chief

Family members of U.P. citizens stranded in Nepal may contact 1070 for information, says State govt.

Minister Yogi Adityanath, to ensure the safety of citizens of the State,” an official statement said.

The government has activated relief and rescue teams along with necessary resources to safely evacuate Uttar Pradesh citizens stranded in Nepal and provide them with immediate assistance. The Control Room of the Relief

Commissioner's Office is continuously monitoring the situation in the districts bordering Nepal, the statement said.

Platoon deployed

The State government has also deployed a 32 member platoon of State Disaster Relief Force (SDRF) for relief and rescue operation in Nepal.

“In addition, 22 personnel from the 26th Battalion of PAC have also been sent to Nepal. The government has made preparations to provide additional forces and resources as required, ensuring that there is no

shortfall in delivering relief to the affected people. Four rubber boats are already available at the site to make the rescue operation effective in flood-affected areas. An aluminium boat is also being sent to Nepal along with an additional SDRF platoon,” the statement added.

The government said that the entire focus was on safely evacuating stranded citizens and ensuring that aid reaches those in need. “Family members of Uttar Pradesh citizens stranded in Nepal may contact 1070 for any information,” it said.

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

A body of two ethnic communities in Sikkim has advised the Centre to learn from the flash flood disaster in Nepal and scrap all new and proposed hydroelectric projects in the Himalayan State.

According to the Nepal Electricity Authority, at least 13 hydropower projects along the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli River corridors suffered extensive damage.

The mudslide hit Gyirong port in Tibet and slammed into Nepal, creat-



The disaster highlights the vulnerability of the Himalayan region, requiring a fresh assessment of development activities

TSETEN TASKI BHUTIA
SIBLAC convenor

ing high-speed flash floods that washed away entire roads, power projects, and inundated villages. The 11-megawatt Rasuwagadhi Hydropower Plant in Rasuwa district of Nepal was among those affected.

On Wednesday evening, the Sikkim Bhutia Lepcha Apex Committee (SIBLAC) urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to halt new hydropower projects in the State and order an independent probe into the existing projects.

SIBLAC convenor Tseten Taski Bhutia, also the chief adviser to the Sikkim unit of the BJP, expressed solidarity with the people of Nepal and hoped for the success of the relief and rescue operations.

“The disaster in Nepal highlights the vulnerability of the Himalayan region, requiring a fresh assess-

ment of development activities,” he said, insisting that the Centre should reconsider plans for new hydroelectric projects on Sikkim's rivers.

Seeking an independent inquiry into the environmental, geological, seismic, social, and national security implications of all existing and proposed projects, he urged the Centre to publish a White Paper containing the findings of such an assessment.

He said the group was not against development, but not at the cost of the ecological and social security of the area.

Rahul attacks Centre over NCLT plan for businessman

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday accused the Centre of creating “two systems” in the country, one for a handful of billionaires and another for everyone else, after the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) approved a resolution plan allowing businessman Subhash Chandra to settle ₹22,006 crore dues for ₹6.5 crore.

In a post on X, Mr. Gandhi quipped that NCLT stood for “Neta-Company Loot Tribunal”. He said, “If a farmer doesn't pay 50 thousand, his land gets auctioned off. If a salaried person misses even one EMI, bank goons show up at the house. Poor students can't even get loans for education.” “But for select ‘friends,’ bank money is like personal property – withdraw as much as you want, repay whatever you feel like,” he said.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh described the settlement as a “mundan”, saying it made “a completely mockery of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, 2016”.

Security tightened at disputed Mathura temple amid ‘Kar Seva’ concerns, HC told

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Mathura administration recently informed the Allahabad High Court that security arrangements were made at the disputed Krishna Janmabhoomi-Shahi Idgah premises amid concerns of ‘Kar Seva’.

‘Kar Seva’ was called by

Hindu religious leaders in Mathura for voluntary action to “liberate” the Krishna Janmabhoomi site.

The Bench, during the hearing of the Original Suit No. 4 of 2023, filed by the Shri Krishna Janmabhoomi Mukti Nirmaan Trust and others against the Shahi Masjid Eidgah Management Committee and oth-

ers, noted that the court had received a report in a sealed cover.

The report had originally been called for by the High Court on July 17, after a plaintiff filed an application asking the court to direct the State Government and local administration to prevent any individual or group from entering the

disputed site to hold meetings, perform Kar Seva, or organise events that might disturb public peace.

The court is presently hearing 18 suits that seek the removal of the Shahi Idgah, which they claim is an encroachment on the premises of the temple.

The matter will now be heard on September 18.

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Announces Call for Applications under "Biotechnology Career Advancement and Re-Orientatation (BioCARE) Programme for Women Researchers" for 2026-27

Department of Biotechnology, Ministry of Science & Technology, Government of India invites the applications under the BioCARE Programme for women researchers for the year 2026-27. The programme is targeted to enhance the participation of women researchers in India towards research in Biotechnology and allied areas.
Detailed information on the fellowship grant, eligibility criteria, guidelines and application process is available at DBT website - <https://dbt.gov.in/> and RCB website - <https://rcb.res.in/DBTBioCARE/> To apply, interested applicants may kindly visit Common Fellowship Portal via <https://fellowships.gov.in/>.
Start Date of Online Application : 25th August, 2026
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For any queries, please contact DBT-HRD Project & Management Unit, Regional Centre for Biotechnology at biocare.dbt@rcb.res.in.

$MCH-CH_2$

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SOLID TECHNIQUE

Padikkal produced good Test-match batting: Kirsten



PTI

Devdutt Padikkal gained a fan in Gary Kirsten. The Sri Lanka coach said: “I liked the way Padikkal batted. The thing with players, who play multiple formats, is that they tend to replicate the style but Padikkal produced good Test-match batting. His innings at Galle was special, he has a solid game”.

IMMOVABLE OBJECT

Dinusha batted really well and hardly offered any chances: Gill



AP

Sonal Dinusha may have frustrated the Indians but skipper Shubman Gill lauded Sri Lanka’s latest star. “Dinusha batted really well, he has a good defence, played his shots, swept and drove, hardly offered any chances. We did think about testing him with pace but on this pitch (Colombo) he was comfortable”.

REMARKABLE RUN

Dinusha joins Zimbabwe legend Andy Flower in elite club



PTI

Sonal Dinusha became the second player after Andy Flower to register four successive fifty-plus scores against India in a two-Test series. The Sri Lankan also joined Douglas Jardine, Everton Weekes, Clyde Walcott and Ken Barrington as the fifth batter to score fifty-plus scores in the first four Test innings against India.

DETERMINED

Will keep working hard, being in the XI not in my control: Padikkal



AFP

You always want to play. You want to represent your country and keep working hard. That is the only thing in your control. Being in the XI is not in your control. You have to help your teammates whenever you get an opportunity — Devdutt Padikkal after winning the Player-of-the-Series award against Sri Lanka.

Dinusha keeps India at bay, earns Lanka a draw

The left-hander notches up his third hundred in four innings to take the host to safety along with tailenders Nuwantha and Kumara; Gill’s men finish with a 1-0 series triumph

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

In the instant gratification that limited overs cricket offers, results oscillate between triumphs and defeats. Tests, though, can yield another conclusion, the stalemate, technically called the draw.

A final verdict that remains inconclusive may be presumed dull, but at times a draw can reveal a glorious fightback and reiterate cricket’s philosophical second-skin often whispered as ‘glorious uncertainties’.

Sri Lanka precisely did this while snatching a draw in the second Test against India at the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground on Thursday. Sonal Dinusha (133 n.o., 264b, 8x4, 2x6) scripted this miracle on the concluding day, as the southpaw’s hundred, second in the match, and third in the series, kept the visitor at bay.

The host declared its second innings at 429 for nine, a stunning comeback after conceding a 213-run first innings lead. India had to rest content with a muted series triumph at 1-0 when a 2-0 seemed possible especially after enforcing the follow-on. At one point Mohammed Siraj swapped bails at the striker’s end, and it reflected the despair coursing through Shubman Gill’s men under the harsh Colombo sun.

In the morning, resum-



Heroic deed: Dinusha led a glorious fightback by Sri Lanka on the final day and thwarted India’s victory bid. PTI

ing at 229 for six, Sri Lanka, ahead by a mere 16, found its saviours in Dinusha and Keshara Nuwantha. The duo exhibited synergy and patience while a few miscued shots eluded fielders like Devdutt Padikkal.

Gill switched from spin to pace at both ends as Prasidh Krishna and Siraj operated in tandem. Nuwantha drove Prasidh and after a play-and-miss routine against Siraj, picked two fours off the speedster.

When Ravindra Jadeja stepped in, Dinusha feathered one past a diving leg-slip. Soon the batter got to his 50 and after Nuwantha survived an lbw appeal from Jadeja, Sri Lanka moved to 329 for six at lunch.

The first session that yielded 100 without any loss of wickets, meant that Sri Lanka could keep its hopes alive. After the break, Nuwantha (46, 150b, 4x4) pushed forward to left-arm spinner Manav

Suthar and edged to Dhruv Jurel at first slip. By then he and Dinusha had added 112 runs for the seventh wicket, constituting a vital part of Sri Lanka’s resistance.

Gill attempted a scorched-earth policy against Dinusha. Placing eight fielders on the off-side while Siraj bowled around the off-stump. At times, the field was reversed and then the spearhead pegged away on the leg-side. Wear the Sri Lankans down and trigger a

mistake, seemed to be the plan.

Just that Dinusha remained unruffled. He punched Prasidh past sweeper-cover, and then guided Jadeja over mid-wicket. Meanwhile, Prabath Jayasuriya fell to Jadeja, finding Jurel nearby.

A swept four off Suthar helped Dinusha move to 98 and at tea, the host was 383 for eight, reflecting a dour second session in which 54 runs were scored. When the last act

SCOREBOARD

INDIA — 1ST INNINGS
503 for nine decl. in 138 overs
SRI LANKA — 1ST INNINGS
290 in 89.4 overs

SRI LANKA — 2nd INNINGS

Lahiru Udara c Saransh b Siraj 3 (15b), Kamil Mishara lbw b Jadeja 32 (39b, 3x4, 1x6), Pasindu Sooriyabandara st. Pant b Suthar 92 (173b, 10x4, 1x6), Kamindu Mendis c Gill b Prasidh 55 (92b, 2x4, 3x6), Dhananjaya de Silva c Padikkal b Suthar 23 (44b, 1x4, 1x6), Sonal Dinusha (not out) 133 (264b, 8x4, 2x6), Niroshan Dickwella lbw b Saransh 6 (12b, 1x4), Keshara Nuwantha c Jurel b Suthar 46 (150b, 4x4), Prabath Jayasuriya c Jurel b Jadeja 2 (28b), Lahiru Kumara c Jaiswal b Jadeja 12 (90b, 1x4), Asitha Fernando (not out) 0 (24b); Extras (b-7, lb-8, nb-7, w-3): 25; Total (for nine wkts. decl. in 154 overs): 429.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-5 (Udara, 3.3 overs), 2-63 (Mishara, 14.5), 3-178 (Kamindu, 43.1), 4-209 (Dhananjaya, 58.5), 5-212 (Sooriyabandara, 60.3), 6-218 (Dickwella, 64.2), 7-330 (Nuwantha, 104.4), 8-355 (Prabath, 116.3), 9-402 (Kumara, 144.4).

INDIA BOWLING

Prasidh 18.3-3-57-1, Siraj 15-7-26-1, Suthar 41-7-121-3, Saransh 37-4-98-1, Jadeja 38.3-4-94-3, Gill 2-0-8-0, Jaiswal 1-0-9-0, Jurel 1-2-1-0.

Second Test drawn.

India won two-match series 1-0.

Player-of-the-Match: Dinusha.

Player-of-the-Series: Padikkal.

Gill defends decision to enforce follow-on



One that got away: Gill termed the draw a disappointment. AFP

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

Ever since V.V.S. Laxman and Rahul Dravid ambushed Australia at the Eden Gardens in 2001, most skippers are wary about asking the rival team to bat again. But there are exceptions and Shubman Gill, goaded by the whimsical rains in the Sri Lankan capital, had no hesitation in enforcing the follow-on.

However, the men from the Emerald Isle, admirably guided by centurion Sonal Dinusha gained a hard-fought draw in the second Test here at the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground. Gill, though, felt that given the match-situation, his decision was fine.

“I would not say it (follow-on) backfired. We were also anticipating (wet) weather on day four and five. But you have to take the best decision possible in that situation,” Gill told the media here on Thursday.

Explaining the strategy, the Indian skipper said:

“We attacked in the beginning but as the match went on, the pitch got slower. As a batter, if you know that bowlers do not have two modes of dismissal (bowled and lbw) in play, then it becomes easier to bat. We tried our best but they also batted really well. It was obviously disappointing.”

Looking back at the series, Gill drew heart from the performances of some players: “Devdutt (Padikkal) did really well. And Manav (Suthar), technically this is his first full series, did well. Prasidh (Krishna) has been the pick of our bowlers, been our go-to bowler and created chances. Overall we played good cricket.”

WTC final hopes

And as for a chance in the ICC World Test Championship final, Gill leant on hope: “I still think we have a pretty good chance to qualify. If we play the New Zealand series well and then hopefully when Australia comes, we just have to win that series”.

Smith, Cox shine for England on opening day

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Jamie Smith and Jordan Cox both scored fifties as England recovered from a top-order collapse against Pakistan to reach 248 for nine when bad light ended Thursday’s opening day of the second Test at Lord’s.

Veteran paceman Mohammad Abbas took three wickets for four runs off 16 balls, including the prized scalp of England captain Joe Root for just four, as the host slumped to 36 for three after Pakistan won the toss in helpful conditions for seam bowling.

But Smith’s 61 and Cox’s 55 got England back into the game.

Abbas claimed four for 56 while fellow seamer Mohammad Ali scalped three for 67.

The scores: England 248/9 in 56 overs (Cox 55, Smith 61, Abbas 4/56) vs. Pakistan. Toss: Pakistan.

Alcaraz and Sabalenka handed tough draw



Hands full: Stiff challenges await holder Sabalenka. GETTY IMAGES

US OPEN

Reuters
TORONTO

Defending US Open champion Carlos Alcaraz faces a challenging road to the New York final while Aryna Sabalenka will also have her hands full in her bid for a three-peat, following Thursday’s draw.

Alcaraz, who is returning to singles action after sitting out five months with a wrist injury, landed in the stronger bottom half of

the men’s draw along with former champions Novak Djokovic, Daniil Medvedev, Stan Wawrinka and Marin Cilic.

The Spanish second seed will start against Roman Safiullin.

On the women’s side, top seed Sabalenka will play Colombian Camila Osorio in her opening match and faces a potential quarterfinal clash with reigning Wimbledon champion Linda Noskova and a semifinal showdown with an in-form Jessica Pegula.

Indian women down Germany for best finish since inaugural edition

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

Relevance for World Cup classification matches is a matter of perspective. For this Indian women’s team, which suffered a heart-breaking exit in its push for a semifinal berth, a best-ever finish since the inaugural 1974 edition was at stake.

Having picked itself up to go again, this side earned itself a small piece of history by finishing fifth with a 3-1 win over Germany here at the Wagener Stadion on Thursday.

It was a counter-attacking clinic as goals from Ishika and Navneet Kaur in the second half subdued the World No. 5 ranked side.

Starting the tournament ranked ninth, Sjoerd Marijne’s India exceeded expectations in the Netherlands, pulling off draws



Time for cheer: The Indian women’s team is a happy bunch after beating Germany. X@THEHOCKEYINDIA

against China (ranked fourth), England (seventh) and Australia (eighth) to add to this result.

It will now head into the Asian Games next month, confident of challenging for the gold.

After a passive start, Germany came alive in the second quarter, making multiple circle entries without threatening India’s goal. But it was India which shaded Germany for attempts on goal, when Nav-

neet’s powerful backhanded drive drew a save from Finja Starck. Salima Tete was alive to a couple of rebounds but Starck kicked them both out.

Germany continued to dominate possession for majority of the game, but the Indian defence, which included tournament debutant, Lalhantluangi, held firm.

Then, against the run of play, India opened the scoring after Neha slipped

a through ball for Ishika, who composed herself before lifting the ball past Starck for her first World Cup goal.

India found plenty of joy through Germany’s centre, repeatedly catching its defence out on the counter. After having gone three games without a goal, India suddenly scored three in the space of four minutes.

After going cold from PCs in previous outings, Navneet struck from India’s second short corner before she added another with a cool flick into the roof of the net from another turnover.

Germany persevered in the last stretch with Savita Punia needing to pull off a couple of key saves, but she couldn’t keep out Lynn Krings’ effort with 67 seconds left on the clock.

The result: India 3 (Ishika 42, Navneet Kaur 43-pc, 46) bt Germany 1 (Lynn Krings 58).

PSG to face Barca, City, Villa in UCL

Agence France-Presse
MONACO

Two-time defending champion Paris Saint-Germain was handed meetings with Barcelona, Manchester City and Aston Villa among its eight matches in the league phase of this season’s Champions League, as the draw took place on Thursday.

PSG will play Barcelona, Roma, Turkish champion Galatasaray and Slovan Bratislava of Slovakia at home.

Luis Enrique’s team will travel to England twice to face City and Villa. The French champion will also go to Spain to play Villarreal and Italy to take on Como.

The first matches in the league phase will be played between September 8 and September 10, with the final games in late January. The UEFA is expected to announce the full fixture schedule on Saturday.



PTI, AP & AFP

Series victory fails to mask grey areas as India prepares for daunting challenges

Padikkal blossomed, Jurel showed his worth and Prasidh hit his stride in the Emerald Isle; however, the tour exposed a thinning spin cupboard

R. Kaushik
COLOMBO

How often does a draw feel like a defeat? And a stalemate assume the hue of a victory? Often enough, Shubman Gill will insist.

Despite their own uneasy recent dalliance with the five-day format, India would have fancied their chances of bearding the Sri Lankan lion in its own den in a two-Test series that is pretty much the norm when the world's most sought-after side isn't playing against Australia or England.

India hadn't lost a series in this country since 2008 and arrived early this month sitting on a five-Test winning streak on Sri Lankan soil. Even though their last visit was in 2017, they had reason to believe the hosts were ripe for the taking.

Significant result

The script seemed to be holding true. Notwithstanding pockets of defiance from their young guns, led by the exceptional Sonal Dinusha, Sri Lanka slumped to a 185-run rout in Galle in the first Test. The result assumed a more significant hue because India were without two-fifths of their first-choice bowling attack – Jasprit Bumrah and Washington Sundar were missing through injuries – but still won a rain-hit encounter with quite a bit to spare.

There was excellent reason, therefore, to aspire for a 2-0 sweep ahead of the second Test at the SSC ground. Sri Lanka, already without Pathum Nissanka and Kusal Mendis, were dealt another unkind cut when Dinesh Chandimal was ruled out of the second Test after hurting his neck while fielding in Galle. But as it turned out, his replacement, Pasindu Sooriyabandara, had a great game at the SSC, desperately unlucky to miss out of centuries in both innings.

Dinusha delights

Dinusha, however, ensured that a similar fate didn't befall him. Ahead of this series, the 25-year-old left-hander had played just three Tests but had showcased his ability and his temperament, not least in the Caribbean in June-July when he reeled off a sequence of 43, 12 not out, 92 and 28 in the two Tests.

It should have been fair warning well heeded; it will be presumptuous to say that India didn't pay much attention to the young man, but they didn't crack the Dinusha puzzle throughout the series, which is one of the main reasons they had to settle for a 1-0 scoreline despite dominating the second Test too for large stretches.

Dinusha batted for a little less than 20 hours in making 420 runs from 722 deliveries, the single point of difference as the Lankans ground out a fabulous draw

after being forced to follow on in the second Test.

It wasn't all doom and gloom from an Indian point of view. Devdutt Padikkal grabbed his chances with both hands in his first Tests in more than 20 months. In the absence of Sai Sudharsan, he took giant strides towards making the No. 3 slot his own with hundreds in the first innings of both games.

The volume of runs was impressive, but so was his presence in the middle. In further signs of his evolution as a dependable, oftentimes aggressive all-format batter, he treated the bowling with just about the respect it deserved, using the offside as his preferred area of scoring and looking equally comfortable against pace and spin.

India will find it very hard to look beyond him for the one-drop position when they play two Tests in New Zealand in November. After all, how can you overlook the credentials of someone as consistent as the Karnataka left-hander was in Sri Lanka?

And then, there was Dhruv Jurel, justifying the faith of the Gautam Gambhir-led think-tank which was sure that the wicketkeeper-batter was the answer to their prayers for a dependable middle-order batter who could play spin with soft hands, deftness of feet and no gremlins of self-doubt.

Assured batting

Alongside Sai Sudharsan and Padikkal, Jurel was one of the three batters Gambhir was keen should be a part of the India 'A' side that arrived on these shores for a shadow tour towards the end of June. Admittedly, neither Galle nor the SSC was a rank turner like Kolkata had been against South Africa in November, but Jurel didn't put a foot wrong either in front of the stumps – he had a half-century in the first Test which he topped with his second ton in the next – or behind it when Rishabh Pant sat out much of the Sri Lankan first innings in Colombo with an assortment of blows to his body.

K.L. Rahul was dependable without going big while Pant was, well, Pant – exhilarating, unpredictable, entertaining and compelling. Maybe Gill will be a little disappointed that he didn't join the list of centuries, but his batting looked in decent order, as did Yashasvi Jaiswal's even if he found novel ways of courting dismissals.

Then, there was Prasidh Krishna. Ahead of the series, Gill was asked if he had a difficult choice to make between the Karnataka pacer and the uncapped Gurnoor Brar as Mohammed Siraj's new-ball partner. The skipper barely batted an eyelid when he said that Prasidh was bowling the best with the red ball that he had ever seen him, and the strapping quick didn't disappoint.

Even on the placid decks on offer, he worked up good pace, extracted appreciable bounce and kept the batters honest. When he pitched the ball up, there was movement which, allied with pace in the region of 140 kmph, made him a tricky proposition.

Up for the challenge

Prasidh was up for any challenge, including doing the dirty job of trying to soften up the batters with his shortish length, and is shaping up into an excellent support act for Bumrah and Siraj. India will need their pacers to fire on all cylinders when they go to New Zealand, so from that perspective, the development of Prasidh is perhaps the single greatest takeaway for the decision-making group from this three-week sojourn to the Emerald Isle.

But there are worrying signs aplenty too, not least when it comes to back-up spin options. Despite starting his Test career with so much promise in New Chandigarh when he took six wickets in the first innings against Afghanistan, and despite his ten-wicket match haul in Galle, Manav Suthar is still very much a work in progress.

In Colombo, his craft had to play second fiddle to the slowness of the SSC strip; there was bounce aplenty, which took bowled and leg before out of the equation, but the left-arm spinner was slow to respond when the Sri Lankan batters resorted to the sweep and the reverse sweep.

It might appear a touch harsh on someone who was only playing in his third Test, but this is an early education for Suthar and he will do well to heed the lessons if he aspires to step into the shoes of Ravindra Jadeja going forward and become the lead bowler around whom the Indian spin attack will revolve in the future.

Debut to forget

While Suthar did show signs of promise, Saransh Jain had a disappointing debut – and there is no way to sugarcoat that. On the radar of those involved in talent-identification and selection matters for a while now, Jain is an experienced hand at 33, with more than 50 first-class appearances under his belt for various outfits.

His first delivery in Test cricket was a no-ball, which can perhaps be put down to nerves, but he bowled six more of them across the two innings, which couldn't have pleased anyone, least of all new spin bowling coach Sairaj Bahutule. But it wasn't just the no-balls that were grating. While he did show reasonable control, the threat quotient was barely perceptible.

Saransh wouldn't have been here if Washington was available but as a fallback alternative, he has a long way to go. In

some ways, it points to a slight thinning of resources in the spin cupboard, which ought to worry those in the corridors of power because for so long now, India have got used to having the now-retired R. Ashwin and Jadeja to spin their webs of deception and lure batters to their doom.

After a lull, India have plenty of fast-bowling options to summon despite Mukesh Kumar and Akash Deep and Harshit Rana and Nitish Kumar Reddy spending a lot of time in the infirmary. But for the traditional land of spin to struggle to unearth an incisive off-spinner is a little hard to fathom and harder still to digest.

Jain deserves the benefit of doubt – after all, this was Test No. 1 and maybe he did have the proverbial ordinary one-off game – but for him to set himself up as a semi-long-term option, there must be obvious signs of improvement.

This tour in general, and the second Test particularly, was a steep learning curve for the captain. It's been a little over 14 months since Gill first led the Test team, in England in Leeds last June. Captaincy looks simple from the outside but entails plenty of decision-making on the fly, even in Test cricket, without second-guessing oneself.

He was handicapped by a rapidly softening ball in Galle and by an SSC surface that had bounce but hardly any pace. Some of the fields he employed were strange, there was a definite occasional slant towards passivity, and the move to almost ignore trying to get Dinusha out on the final day of the series and target the other end was little short of self-defeating.

Mixed run

Gill has had a mixed run as captain – 2-2 in England, 2-0 at home against West Indies, defeat in his only Test against South Africa in Kolkata when he faced a mere three deliveries before contracting a neck injury, a hammering of Afghanistan and now this 1-0 success in Sri Lanka, his first overseas victory as skipper.

The journey has been challenging and exciting, but daunting outings lie in store in the red-ball version before he starts to focus exclusively on the 50-over format ahead of the World Cup in southern Africa in the second half of next year.

India haven't won a Test in New Zealand since 2009 when Mahendra Singh Dhoni led them to a famous series triumph, and their last visit in 2020 was an unmitigated disaster as they were soundly beaten in both matches.

New Zealand will test the technique and the character of the batting group with its seam-friendly conditions, after which Australia will come calling for five Tests in India. Gill must be on top of his game – as lead batter and as leader – and towards that end, Sri Lanka was a timely, useful wake-up call.

THE GIST

- ▼ Padikkal has taken giant strides towards making the No. 3 slot his own with hundreds in the first innings of both games at Galle and Colombo
- ▼ Even on the placid decks on offer, Prasidh worked up good pace, extracted appreciable bounce and kept the batters honest
- ▼ Jurel has emerged as a dependable middle-order batter who can play spin with soft hands and deftness of feet without any self-doubt
- ▼ Dinusha's patient and purposeful batting was one of the reasons India was unable to make the second Test its own

HEALTH

The changing face of skin lightening practices in India

The language around skin lightening has changed, but the desire for it has remained strong in India; a lot of the advertisement and marketing has now moved online; the country needs strong legislation, campaigns to educate patients, pharmacists and healthcare professionals, and a conversation that shifts the focus to skin health, not colour

Monisha Madhumita

The language of fairness may be changing, but the desire for lighter skin has not necessarily disappeared in our country. As skin-lightening practices move into skincare, dermatological procedures and digital spaces, the health consequences are becoming increasingly harder to recognise and regulate.

Skin lightening in India is changing. The fairness creams that once dominated advertisements are less visible today. The language around them has also shifted. Words such as ‘brightening’, ‘glow’, ‘de-tan’ and ‘even tone’ are now common across skincare products and digital platforms.

For dermatologists, this change is increasingly visible in clinical practice.

Patients may not come to the clinic saying that they have been trying to become fairer. They often present because something has already gone wrong. There may be acne, redness, thinning of the skin, increased facial hair, pigmentation or infections. Oral agents used with the expectation of achieving lighter skin are also being sought.

“We see patients because of the side-effects of what they have tried, and then work backwards,” says Rashmi Sarkar, head and director - professor, department of dermatology Vardhman Mahavir Medical College and Safdarjung hospital, New Delhi.

The profile is changing too. What was once viewed largely as a concern among women is now also seen among men, teenagers and transgender persons. This makes skin lightening an important skin-health issue, rather than simply a cosmetic concern.

Not all treatment that reduces pigmentation is skin lightening.

Melasma and post-inflammatory hyperpigmentation are common pigmentary disorders. They can be persistent and distressing, particularly in darker skin tones. These conditions may require treatment. The important distinction, Dr. Sarkar says, is between treating a pigmentary disorder and attempting to lighten a person’s normal, constitutive skin colour. This distinction is becoming less clear to consumers.

A product described as ‘brightening’ may be intended to reduce pigmentation, improve dullness or make the skin appear more even. The term itself does not explain what is being changed.

For clinicians, the focus should remain on skin health. Brighter-looking skin can follow better photoprotection, appropriate skincare, control of inflammation and improvements in general health and lifestyle. None of these requires changing a person’s natural skin colour.

Digital shift

The larger change is taking place online.

Skin-lightening messages are no longer limited to television advertisements or product packaging. They are increasingly delivered through influencers, e-commerce platforms, before-and-after photographs and social media.



Need for regulation: Skin-lightening messages are no longer limited to television advertisements or product packaging. They are increasingly delivered through influencers, e-commerce platforms, before-and-after photographs and social media. GETTY IMAGES

Algorithms can amplify these messages. A person who watches one video on pigmentation may subsequently be shown repeated content around brightening products, supplements, peels or procedures. Filters and image manipulation add another layer. Photographs can be altered to make skin appear lighter, smoother or more uniform. Artificial intelligence can make these alterations increasingly difficult to recognise.

Dr. Sarkar believes public education, must therefore, also address digital literacy. People need to learn to recognise filtered or manipulated images and to question the aesthetic standards repeatedly presented to them online.

The impact is particularly relevant for younger users. Repeated exposure can gradually alter what is perceived as normal skin and what is considered a problem requiring correction.

Excessive treatment

The growth of aesthetic skincare has also widened the number of places where people seek treatment.

Patients may move between dermatology clinics, aesthetic centres, salons, spas, social media and online marketplaces. The distinction between medical treatment and cosmetic marketing can become unclear.

Dr. Sarkar stresses that pigmentary disorders should be assessed by qualified dermatologists. Procedures also need to be selected carefully and patients should not be overtreated. This is particularly relevant in darker skin tones, where inflammation caused by aggressive treatment can itself lead to further pigmentation. The treatment can then become part of the problem.

There is also a role for clinicians in managing expectations. Not every variation in skin colour requires treatment. Unregulated over-the-counter

skin-lightening products should be avoided and unrealistic expectations need to be addressed early.

The health consequences can be significant. The International League of Dermatological Societies (ILDS) has warned that the misuse of potent topical corticosteroids in skin-bleaching products can contribute to treatment-resistant fungal infections, irreversible skin damage and systemic side-effects. The organisation has called for stronger regulation, clearer guidance and better public education.

Beyond the clinic

The response to skin lightening therefore also needs to change.

Traditional awareness campaigns remain important, but they may no longer be sufficient when much of the contemporary conversation is taking place online. This is a particular focus of the ILDS Strategic Working Group on Skin Bleaching. The group brings together international dermatology expertise to address harmful skin-lightening practices while also recognising the legitimate need for safe, evidence-based treatment of pigmentary disorders.

The message, says Dr. Sarkar, who is part of the working group, needs to reach people where these practices are now being discussed and promoted. “We need to leverage social media and amplify the message,” she says. This includes closer collaboration between the ILDS and national dermatology societies, as well as engagement with pharmacists, educators and credible public voices.

India has previously seen organised campaigns around inappropriate topical steroid use. These efforts included education of both patients and pharmacists. A similar approach is now needed for contemporary skin-lightening practices.

The ILDS initiative also has a wider

aim: to move the conversation away from skin colour as an aesthetic hierarchy and towards skin health. The message is simple, but important. Healthy skin exists in every shade.

For those experimenting with skincare routines, particularly skin lightening, it means understanding the difference between a pigmentary disorder and normal skin colour. It means recognising that medicines used without appropriate supervision can damage the skin. It means knowing that repeated procedures are not always better treatment. Increasingly, it also means understanding that the images seen online may have been filtered, lightened or otherwise altered.

Regulation will need to evolve alongside this change. Looking only for products explicitly labelled as ‘fairness’ products will miss part of the contemporary market. Claims, ingredients, digital advertising, influencer marketing and access to potent medicines all require attention. But regulation alone cannot address the deeper issue.

Greater awareness has made overt fairness advertising less acceptable. Yet, as Dr. Sarkar points out, social perceptions around skin colour continue to persist. The challenge is therefore no longer only the fairness cream. The people seeking these interventions are also changing. The response now needs to change with them.

For dermatologists, professional societies and public-health organisations, the opportunity lies in moving beyond treating complications after they occur. The focus must be on prevention, evidence-based care, digital education and a clearer understanding of what healthy skin actually means.

(Dr. Monisha Madhumita is a consultant dermatologist at Saveetha Medical College, Chennai. mail.monisha.m@gmail.com)

THE GIST

As skin-lightening practices move into skincare, dermatological procedures and digital spaces, the health consequences are becoming increasingly harder to recognise and regulate

For clinicians, the focus should remain on skin health. Brighter-looking skin can follow better photoprotection, appropriate skincare, control of inflammation and improvements in general health and lifestyle. None of these requires changing a person’s natural skin colour

There is also a role for clinicians in managing expectations. Not every variation in skin colour requires treatment. Unregulated over-the-counter skin-lightening products should be avoided and unrealistic expectations need to be addressed early

Salmonella infections: why India needs to look beyond typhoid and diarrhoea

Athira Elssa Johnson

Salmonella is often linked to food poisoning, diarrhoea and typhoid. But the infection can range from mild gastroenteritis that gets better on its own to a serious bloodstream infection, and therefore, say experts, deserves more attention than it is currently being given.

Salmonella is a group of bacteria that can cause different infections. Typhoid and paratyphoid or enteric fever, are caused by Salmonella Typhi and Salmonella Paratyphi. The problem, however, is broader than typhoid. Non-typhoidal Salmonella infections, which often cause gastroenteritis, may go undiagnosed because many people recover without testing. At the same time, antibiotic resistance is making serious infections harder to treat.

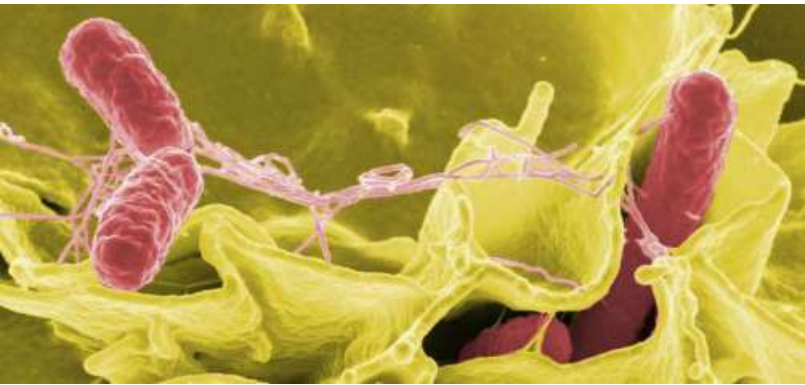
Why infections turn serious

Non-typhoidal Salmonella commonly causes gastroenteritis, with diarrhoea, stomach cramps, fever and sometimes vomiting. It is

often linked to poultry, eggs and other animal-based foods. Most healthy people recover with supportive care, but the infection can become serious and spread to the bloodstream. “Salmonella should not be seen as only a cause of diarrhoea,” said Sweatha Kumar, associate consultant, infectious diseases, Rela Hospital, Chennai. “In some patients, especially young children, older adults and those living with other illnesses or weakened immunity, it can become invasive and life-threatening.”

Suresh Kumar D., senior specialist in infectious diseases, Apollo Speciality Hospitals, Vanagaram, Chennai, said the actual burden of non-typhoidal Salmonella is difficult to estimate as many mild infections are never diagnosed.

Both typhoid and non-typhoidal Samonella infections spread through the faecal-oral route, but their sources are different. For typhoid, humans are the reservoir. Non-typhoidal Salmonella has a wider ecology, involving animals, food and the environment. Poultry,



Preventing infections: Typhoid conjugate vaccines, safer water and sanitation, food safety and antimicrobial stewardship all have a role in reducing infections. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

eggs, meat and other animal-derived foods can be sources. Transmission can also occur when raw meat contaminates ready-to-eat food during preparation.

“Contamination can occur at multiple points, from farms, slaughterhouses and food processing to transportation, storage, restaurants and finally the household kitchen,” Dr. Sweatha said. “That is why Salmonella is very much a One Health problem

involving humans, animals, food and the environment.”

Food handlers can play an important role in transmission, as those carrying the infection can contaminate food and potentially expose many people to the bacteria. But food safety cannot depend only on individual food handlers. The wider system needs better training, sanitation, refrigeration, monitoring and enforcement. While the Food Safety and Standards Authority of

India has surveillance and testing systems, gaps remain, particularly in the large informal food sector.

At the household level, it is important follow: washing hands, using safe water, cooking poultry and eggs thoroughly, refrigerating perishable foods appropriately and keeping raw meat separate from ready-to-eat food.

Challenges and way forward

The major concern is the growing antimicrobial resistance in Salmonella. India has seen a major shift in the resistance pattern of S. Typhi. A recent study in *PLOS Neglected Tropical Diseases* said, culture-confirmed isolates from 1977 to 2024 found that fluoroquinolone resistance rose sharply, reaching 85% in 2015-19, and remains high despite a subsequent decline.

“The emergence and spread of extensively drug-resistant typhoid shows what can happen when resistance accumulates across multiple antibiotic classes,” Dr. Sweatha said, “It can leave clinicians with very limited treatment options.”

Experts say the answer is not to simply use stronger antibiotics. Blood culture is the main test for suspected typhoid and should ideally be done before antibiotics are started. The Widal test has limitations and should not be used alone to diagnose typhoid. For uncomplicated non-typhoidal Salmonella gastroenteritis, treatment mainly involves adequate fluids and electrolyte replacement. Antibiotics are usually reserved for severe or invasive infections and people at higher risk of complications.

Prevention remains as important as treatment. The World Health Organization recommends typhoid conjugate vaccines for children from six months of age; however, this not yet part of India’s universal immunisation programme.

The challenge is to treat the infections that genuinely require antibiotics while preventing the infections that can be prevented in the first place.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of people at risk in Peru due to El Niño

1.2 million. The El Niño weather phenomenon, which has brought some rain and an unexpected rise in temperatures to Peru, could put more than 1 million people at risk in regions of the country vulnerable to climate change, according to national authorities. “Based on historical data from all the regions... approximately 1.2 million people could be affected,” they said. REUTERS

Number of migrants pulled from sea off Mauritania

160 The Mauritanian Coastguard said on Thursday that it had rescued more than 160 migrants, including 17 children, from a boat in trouble off its coast, its second major emergency operation in a week. The migrants were “exhausted by the journey and the insecurity of the vessel” when they were rescued, a Coastguard statement said. AFP

Budget approved by Taiwan lawmakers for locally made drones

7.6 in \$ billion. Lawmakers in Taiwan approved a \$7.6 billion budget for locally made drones on Thursday as the island democracy seeks to strengthen its defences against a potential Chinese attack. Taiwan has ramped up military spending in recent years and is building up its defence industry to make equipment and ammunition on the island. AFP

Number of Indian coal power plants with critical low fuel

45 Forty five power plants in India are operating with critically low coal inventories, government data showed, as monsoon rains disrupt supplies and electricity demand rises. The plants with coal stocks below 25% of their required inventory or with critically low stocks to generate power for less than three days has risen from 31 at the end of July, the data showed. REUTERS

Ladakh’s revised VAT on natural gas to boost clean energy adoption

5 in per cent. Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Thursday announced a significant reduction in value-added tax on natural gas from 21% to 5% to promote affordable clean energy and improve ease of living. He said the move would give a major boost to the Centre’s larger plan to roll out the city gas distribution (CGD) network. PTI
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Can India build a strategic fuel system?

India’s proposed strategic-fuel programme would expand crude, LNG and LPG storage, but building reserves alone will not guarantee energy security; the system will work only if India can move the fuel through ships, pipelines and distribution networks, while having clear rules on ownership, financing, and replenishment

EXPLAINER

Kalyan Mangalapalli

The story so far:

West Asia-related disruptions have exposed a vulnerability in India’s energy-security system. India can import large quantities of crude oil, LNG and LPG, but its ability to store, transport and release these fuels during a prolonged disruption differs sharply by fuel. India already operates underground strategic crude-oil storage and two underground LPG caverns, but has no operating underground natural-gas storage facility. Against this background, the government is considering a decade-long strategic-fuel programme that would add about 28 MT of crude-oil storage, 9 MT of LNG storage and 4 MT of LPG storage. Reuters reports that the proposed reserves are intended to provide nearly two months of crude and LNG demand and about six weeks of LPG demand. The programme remains under consideration and should therefore be treated as a proposed target, not committed capacity.

How much storage does India have today?

India’s position varies considerably by fuel. For crude oil, Phase I of the Strategic Petroleum Reserve provides 5.33 MT of underground capacity, with actual storage of about 3.37 MT, or roughly 63-64% utilisation, across Visakhapatnam, Mangaluru and Padur. A further 6.5 MT has been approved under Phase II at Chandikhol and Padur.

However, execution on the Chandikhol project remains protracted amid ongoing land acquisition requirements and finalisation of commercial PPP frameworks.

LPG has a much smaller underground footprint. The Visakhapatnam and Mangaluru caverns together provide about 0.14 MT of capacity. A proposed 4 MT strategic reserve would therefore represent roughly a 30-fold increase in underground LPG capacity.

Natural gas presents the largest storage gap. India currently has no operational underground gas-storage facility. Its gas-security system instead depends on domestic production, LNG imports, import terminals, commercial inventories and pipelines.

These figures also highlight an important distinction between storage capacity and inventory. A facility has a physical capacity, but the fuel it holds can vary. Not all inventory is necessarily immediately accessible either. During a crisis, the critical measure is therefore not simply how many tonnes can be stored, but how much fuel is available and at what withdrawal rate it can reach consumers.

What does the proposed 9 MT of LNG storage mean?

LNG is particularly prone to confusion because India already has substantial LNG import and regasification infrastructure. A regasification terminal can receive LNG and convert it into natural gas, but its regasification capacity does not constitute strategic inventory.

LNG is stored as a cryogenic liquid at around -162°C, requiring specialised insulated tanks and boil-off gas management. Underground gas storage is different: LNG is first regasified and the resulting natural gas is injected into a depleted reservoir or cavern.



India already operates underground strategic crude-oil storage and two underground LPG caverns, but has no operating underground natural-gas storage facility. GETTY IMAGES

The PNGRB-ICF study provides a useful but narrowly defined stress test. Its 2030 scenario examined how much additional LNG infrastructure would be required to supply priority consumers for 20 days under stress conditions. It estimated a requirement of about 0.56-0.6 MT of LNG equivalent, achievable with roughly eight additional LNG tanks. The combined cost of the tanks and the associated strategic inventory was estimated at around \$1 billion. This was a scenario-specific estimate, not an assessment of India’s overall strategic LNG requirement.

The proposed 9 MT strategic inventory is an order of magnitude larger. Against the ICF projection of roughly 58 MT of annual LNG imports, 9 MT represents about 56 days of imports – hence the description of approximately two months of LNG import cover. It does not mean two months of India’s total gas consumption.

The difference is important. A 0.6 MT requirement addresses a 20-day priority-sector stress scenario; 9 MT represents a much broader strategic objective of buffering India against prolonged LNG-import disruption. The associated investment would therefore be substantially larger.

Does all the gas have to be stored as LNG?

No. India could eventually use a portfolio of surface LNG tanks and underground natural-gas storage.

Additional LNG tanks would hold inventory directly at import terminals. A separate proposal from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas would require LNG import terminals to maintain storage capacity 10% above their normal operating requirement, with the additional capacity available to the government during supply or price disruptions.

For longer-duration requirements, depleted oil and gas reservoirs, which account for 74% of global working gas volume, could provide much larger volumes of underground gas storage. Salt caverns offer different advantages: faster injection and withdrawal and the ability to cycle inventory more frequently, potentially making them useful for

shorter-duration balancing.

But a depleted field cannot simply become a storage site because production has ended. Reservoir characteristics, cap-rock integrity, pressure behaviour, existing wells, cushion-gas requirements and pipeline connectivity must all be assessed. India’s sedimentary basins – including Krishna, Godavari, Cambay, Mumbai Offshore and Rajasthan – offer potential locations, but moving from geological potential to usable storage requires subsurface investigation, site selection, engineering, construction, testing, filling and pipeline integration.

Salt caverns face a similar qualification process. Rajasthan’s salt-bearing formations have been investigated for solution-mined caverns, but suitability depends on depth, thickness, purity, geometry, groundwater and mechanical properties.

Can India scale its crude and LPG experience?

Crude is the most mature component. India already operates underground crude caverns and has developed the associated engineering capabilities. The U.S. Strategic Petroleum Reserve illustrates the scale possible with salt caverns, with authorised capacity of 714 million barrels across 60 caverns. But the U.S. system works as an integrated network of caverns, pipelines, marine terminals and refineries. Storage is therefore fundamentally an infrastructure system, not simply an underground space.

LPG is technically proven in India but presents a much larger scaling challenge. A proposed 4 MT reserve would require a substantial network of new caverns or other storage facilities, together with import terminals, pipelines, pumping systems and bottling infrastructure.

The Mangaluru cavern illustrates the complexity. Underground construction requires geological and hydrogeological investigation, rock-mechanics analysis and groundwater management, particularly where work takes place alongside operating surface facilities. Scaling the system would require sustained capabilities in geophysics, geomechanics, tunnelling, reservoir engineering and project execution.

What happens if the fuel cannot reach India?

Because energy security relies heavily on maritime logistics, including vulnerable chokepoints such as the Strait of Hormuz and long-distance routes from the U.S., India is proactively diversifying both its import sources and shipping capabilities. To reduce reliance on foreign vessels, State-run oil refiners and the Shipping Corporation of India plan to invest \$1.5 to \$2 billion in a joint venture to acquire 59 ships. Simultaneously, Indian Oil is expanding sourcing through new 2027 agreements with Algeria and increased U.S. purchases, while exploring direct stakes in Very Large Gas Carriers to secure greater control over its supply chain.

What about pipelines?

Pipelines provide the final link between imported or stored fuel and inland consumers. PNGRB has recently authorised approximately 1,800 km of new LPG pipelines across six States, involving investment of around \$0.7 billion. These pipelines improve connections between supply sources and inland markets and reduce dependence on road movement, but they do not themselves add strategic storage. Their value lies in improving deliverability.

The same principle applies to natural gas. Underground storage is useful only if it can inject into and withdraw from the gas grid at the required rate. LNG tanks are useful only when regasification and downstream pipelines can move the gas. LPG caverns require connections to bottling and distribution systems.

Who pays for the strategic reserves?

The reported \$42 billion programme, which has yet to be confirmed by the government, combines infrastructure CAPEX with the cost of purchasing and maintaining strategic fuel inventories. Reuters reported that more than half could go towards storage infrastructure, with the balance used to purchase and fill the reserves. Financing would be a challenge and the government shot down reports that a cess would be charged to pay for the reserves.

The financial obligation does not end with construction. Billions of dollars of fuel would need to be purchased, financed and maintained. Stocks released during a crisis would then have to be replenished, potentially when commodity and freight prices are higher. The policy therefore needs to establish who owns and finances the inventory, minimum stock obligations, emergency-release authority, and who bears replenishment and price risk. A commercial-cum-strategic model could reduce the public burden, provided commercially used capacity remains available during emergencies.

Is storage enough to make India energy-secure?

Building 41 MT of combined storage is only part of the equation. A strategic reserve is effective only if India can seamlessly access fuel, transport it inland, and replenish stocks after a release.

Ultimately, energy security relies on an integrated framework: reserves buy time, shipping brings the next cargo, pipelines deliver fuel inland, and governance dictates emergency execution. The ultimate test of India’s strategic fuel programme will be its ability to coordinate all these elements simultaneously when a crisis hits. *(The author is an Energy and Emerging Technologies expert)*

THE GIST

India’s existing strategic storage differs sharply by fuel, with crude having the most developed system, LPG a limited underground footprint and natural gas no operational underground storage facility.

The proposed 28 MT of crude, 9 MT of LNG and 4 MT of LPG reserves would represent a major expansion, but the LNG requirement should not be confused with existing regasification capacity or narrower 20-day stress scenarios.

Geological suitability, infrastructure and project execution will determine how quickly storage can scale, while shipping and pipelines remain critical to ensuring fuel reaches consumers during prolonged disruptions.

Gulzar at 92: the remarkable art of staying relevant without ever standing still

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